THE SMALL-BUSINESS PLAYBOOK

WHO ARE YOU HIRING?



Stopping Deepfake Candidates, Identity Fraud, and Risky Remote Onboarding

ZIRLANDIA MILKOVIC

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This book is practical guidance, not legal, employment, immigration or data-protection advice. Named businesses and people in examples are composites and are labelled as illustrative.

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Before You Begin

Important notice. This book is practical guidance for small businesses. It is not legal, employment, immigration, data-protection or cyber-insurance advice, and it is not a substitute for advice from a qualified professional who knows your business, your country and your circumstances. Laws on identity checks, right to work, employment practices and data protection differ between countries and change often. Where this book mentions a rule, it points to the source it was checked against and the date; please confirm the current position before you rely on it.

About the examples. Every named business, person and scenario in this book that is not attributed to a source is a composite, written to illustrate a point. They are marked *Illustrative example*. They are not real events and any resemblance to a real company or individual is coincidental. Facts that come from public sources are numbered and listed in *Sources and Further Reading* at the end.

About the statistics. This book contains very few numbers on purpose. Where a figure comes from a vendor survey or a single research report, the text says so and says what the figure can and cannot show. Nothing here is invented to make a point sound more urgent.

Research cut-off. Sources were reviewed in late October 2026.

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Introduction: The Person on the Screen

Imagine you run a twelve-person software and services company. Hiring has been slow, and you have finally found a developer who looks ideal. Their CV is clean, their portfolio is polished, their answers in two video interviews were fluent, and their references replied quickly. You make an offer. A laptop goes out in the post. On day one they are given access to your code repository, your cloud console and the shared drive that holds customer contracts.

Now imagine that the person you interviewed, the person whose name is on the contract, and the person who is actually logging in are not the same person. Perhaps the CV was assembled from someone else's real career. Perhaps the face on the video call was real but the voice and answers were being fed to them. Perhaps the laptop you posted is sitting on a shelf in a house you have never heard of, with someone else controlling it remotely.

That is the risk this book is about. It is not science fiction, and it is not a reason to stop hiring remote workers. It is an ordinary business risk with an ordinary business answer: a **repeatable process** that makes it hard for the wrong person to get from "applicant" to "trusted insider".

What the evidence actually says

You do not need to take this on trust. Several credible organisations have described the pattern.

- In June 2022 the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) reported an increase in complaints about **deepfakes and stolen personal information being used to apply for remote and work-**

from-home jobs. The roles involved IT, programming, database and software functions, some with access to customer data, financial data, corporate IT databases or proprietary information. Complainants described voice spoofing in online interviews and video in which lip movements did not fully match the audio. [1]

- In January 2025, July 2025 and October 2026 the FBI published further alerts on North Korean IT worker schemes, describing stolen identities, facilitators who receive company laptops, remote-access tools, and the use of artificial intelligence and face-swapping technology during video interviews. [2][3][4]
- Recorded Future's Insikt Group has published research on a cluster of fraudulent employment activity it calls PurpleDelta. It reports that one cluster of operators applied to jobs at more than 1,100 companies, maintained at least 22 fabricated personas, and used AI-generated profile photos and custom ChatGPT assistants to answer interview questions in character. [5]
- In the UK, the background-screening company First Advantage reports that 69% of UK hiring leaders it surveyed see AI-enabled impersonation and deepfakes as the most sophisticated emerging threat to recruitment integrity. That figure comes from a vendor with a commercial interest in identity checks and the published summary does not give its methodology, so treat it as an indication of concern among hiring professionals, not as a measurement of how common the fraud is. [6]

Two honest caveats belong here. First, much of the most detailed public reporting concerns state-linked schemes aimed mainly at technology companies. A small accountancy firm or a ten-person marketing agency is statistically less likely to meet one of those operations than a software firm. Second, the *techniques* do not stay confined to one kind of actor. Stolen identities, proxy interviewers, borrowed credentials and AI-assisted answers are available to any fraudster or any unscrupulous candidate. The process in this book protects you against the sophisticated case and the opportunistic case alike.

What this book is, and is not

This is a **hiring-security** book. Its subject is narrow: how to be reasonably sure that the person you hire is the person you think you are hiring, and how to limit the damage if you are wrong.

It is **not** a general guide to AI, privacy or scams. It does not teach you to "spot a deepfake" by staring at a video. Chapter 2 explains why that is the wrong approach: the visual and audio cues people hope to rely on are inconsistent, they change as the tools improve, and a process that depends on your eyes will fail at the worst moment. The FBI's own October 2026 alert says that no single indicator reliably identifies these workers and advises looking for several signals together. [4]

Instead, the book is built on five principles.

1. **Nothing you can see on a screen is proof of identity.** Video, CVs, portfolios and references are evidence, not proof. They become useful when you check them *independently*.
2. **Process beats perception.** A short, repeatable checklist applied to every candidate works better than a clever hunch applied to some.
3. **Stage the access.** A new starter should earn trust in steps. The first week should never grant the keys to everything.
4. **Be fair by design.** Checks must be proportionate, privacy-conscious and applied to everyone in the same way. Fraud prevention that discriminates is both unethical and, in many places, unlawful. It is also less effective, because it teaches you to look at the wrong things.
5. **Know what to do when something feels wrong.** A calm, pre-agreed escalation path protects both you and the candidate.

Who this book is for

You are a founder, a business owner, an HR lead, a hiring manager or an IT manager at a company that hires remote or hybrid staff and does not have a dedicated security team. You may be the person who does all of those jobs on a Tuesday afternoon. The advice here is written for you: plain English, short sections, no jargon you cannot act on.

How the book works

Every chapter follows the same shape. It begins with **the problem** you are likely to recognise. It explains the **risk** in simple terms, gives a realistic small-business **example** (always labelled as illustrative), and ends with **this week**, a short list of specific actions that take hours, not months.

The appendices at the back are working documents: checklists, a video-interview protocol, a reference-call script, an incident card, a one-page policy and a thirty-day plan. Chapter 11 shows you how to put them to work in a month. You can read the whole book in an evening, but the real value is in the pages you print and use.

If you only have time for one thing, read Chapter 8 (the gap between the offer and the first day) and Chapter 9 (access). Most real damage is done after the hire, not before.

A final word on tone. Almost every applicant you will ever meet is exactly who they say they are. The goal of this book is not to make you suspicious of people. It is to build a hiring process where honest candidates barely notice the checks, and a dishonest one runs out of road.

CHAPTER 1

The New Hiring Risk: When the Applicant Is Not Who They Claim to Be



The problem you may recognise

You post a remote role. Within a day you have more applications than you can read. Many look excellent. Some are suspiciously similar to each other. You do not have time to investigate any of them, so you shortlist on how good the CV looks, run a video call, check one reference and make a decision. It feels reasonable, because it is how hiring has always worked.

The trouble is that every step in that familiar process was designed for a world in which pretending to be someone else was hard. It is now cheap.

The risk in plain language

"Fake candidate" is not one thing. It helps to separate several different situations, because they call for slightly different defences.

1. The stolen or borrowed identity. The person applying uses a real individual's name, work history and personal details. The real individual may not know. The FBI's 2022 alert noted that some victims found their identities had been used to apply for jobs they never applied for, and that employers discovered the problem when background checks showed that the personal information belonged to someone else. [1]

2. The invented identity. A persona is created from nothing: a name, an AI-generated profile photo, a plausible CV, a portfolio and a set of online accounts. Recorded Future's research on the PurpleDelta cluster describes operators who maintained multiple fabricated personas, with AI-generated profile photos and, for each identity, a custom-configured chatbot used to answer interview questions in character. [5]

3. The proxy interviewer. One person does the interviews and another does the job. The person who impresses you on camera is a skilled stand-in. The FBI's July 2025 alert describes facilitators who attend virtual interviews on someone else's behalf and notes that the person interviewing may differ from the person doing the work. [3]

4. The assisted candidate. A real candidate, using their own name, quietly relies on live transcription and an AI assistant to produce answers during interviews or technical tests. This is not always identity fraud, but it means your assessment measured the tool, not the person. Whether it is acceptable depends on your rules, and the rules should be stated up front (see Chapters 5 and 6).

5. The access broker. Someone is genuinely hired, but they are not the person doing the work, or they hand control of the company laptop and accounts to another party. The FBI describes "laptop

farm" arrangements in which company laptops are received and configured by facilitators who then enable remote access for workers elsewhere. [3]

6. The ordinary exaggerator. Not every problem is high-tech. Inflated qualifications, invented job titles and concealed gaps have always existed. The same verification habits that stop a sophisticated fraud also catch these.

Why small businesses should care

A reasonable reader might think: "This sounds like a problem for banks and defence contractors." There are two reasons it is not only that.

First, **small businesses are often easier to get into**. A large employer may have a background-check vendor, a security team and a long onboarding period. A small business often has an owner who is keen to fill a role quickly, informal onboarding and broad access granted on day one. Those are exactly the conditions in which a fraudulent hire is most likely to succeed.

Second, **the access is the prize, not the salary**. The FBI's 2022 alert highlighted roles that could reach customer personal data, financial data, corporate IT databases and proprietary information. [1] A small company with a few thousand customer records and a code repository holds precisely the kind of assets that matter. Recorded Future reports that, in addition to earning wages, operators were able to collect high-value intelligence and take proprietary data, source code and internal communications. [5]

Honesty requires a counterweight. The best-documented schemes target technology, software, staffing and consulting firms, and healthcare and biotech. [5] If you hire a barista, a bookkeeper in person, or a warehouse picker, the chance of meeting a state-linked

operation is low. But your business still has an interest in knowing who is on your payroll, and if any role you hire remotely touches money, customer data, source code or systems, you are in scope.

Illustrative example

> **Illustrative example.** *Harbour & Finch* is an invented 14-person digital agency. It needs a back-end developer quickly, advertises on a general job board and receives 180 applications. Three CVs share unusual phrasing in their "about me" sections. One candidate, "Daniel", interviews well on two calls, always from a blurred virtual background, with his camera slightly low-resolution "because of the connection". His references are two email addresses at free webmail domains, both of which reply within the hour with glowing comments. He asks for the laptop to be sent to his sister's address "because I am moving". Nobody at Harbour & Finch has done anything wrong yet. But at every step a different small check was available, and none was used: a cross-check of the shared phrasing, a live ID comparison, an independently sourced reference, and a rule that equipment only goes to the address verified in the hiring file. This book is the set of those small checks.

What you are protecting

It helps to be specific about what a bad hire could reach. Chapter 3 goes into detail, but for now think of four things:

- **Systems**: email, cloud accounts, code, admin consoles.
- **Data**: customer records, employee records, contracts, financial data.
- **Money**: payroll, invoices, supplier payments, company cards, expenses.

- **Reputation**: your clients' trust, your regulatory standing and your name.

What "good" looks like

A small business does not need a security operations centre. It needs a hiring process in which:

- identity is **verified through a channel the candidate does not control**;
- the same checks apply to **every candidate for a role**;
- trust is **released in stages**, and sensitive access waits for verification to finish;
- someone **owns** the process, and everyone knows who to tell if something looks wrong;
- candidates are **told what to expect**, so honest people are not surprised or offended.

The rest of the book builds exactly that.

This week

- ☐ List every role you hired for remotely in the last 12 months and mark which ones had access to customer data, money, code or admin systems.
- ☐ Write down, in one paragraph, how your current process confirms that a new hire is the person on the CV. If the paragraph is "we met on video and checked a reference", you have found your starting point.
- ☐ Decide who owns hiring security. It can be a founder, an HR lead or an IT manager, but it must be a named person.
- ☐ Read the FBI's 2022 public service announcement [1]. It is short and a good reference point for your team.

CHAPTER 2

Why "Seeing Them on Video" Is No Longer Enough



The problem you may recognise

You pride yourself on judging people. You have interviewed hundreds. You think you can tell when someone is genuine. After a video call you feel certain: "I looked them in the eye, and they were real."

That instinct is understandable and, in this context, unreliable.

The risk in plain language

A video call proves one thing: that *some* person was sending you *some* video and audio at that moment. It does not prove whose face it was, whose voice, whose knowledge, or who will turn up on day one. Several things have changed at once.

Appearance can be altered. Face-swapping and voice-changing tools exist and are discussed in official warnings. The FBI's 2025 alert lists "use of artificial intelligence or face-swapping technology during video interviews" as a red flag. [2] Its 2022 alert reported voice spoofing and video in which lip movements and sounds did not line up with what was shown. [1]

Answers can be fed. Recorded Future's PurpleDelta research describes real-time transcription tools passing interviewers' questions to a chatbot, with operators often repeating its answers word for word, even when wrong. [5] Notice what that means: the *words* you judge may not be the candidate's own.

Documents can be produced. The same research reports identity cards from a paid generator service. [5] The FBI also warns that operators use stolen identities and buy verification accounts to pass background checks. [4]

Another person can stand in. The FBI reports facilitators who attend virtual interviews for the worker, so the face you see may differ from the person doing the job. [3]

None of this means every video call is fake. It means a video call, on its own, can no longer carry the weight of "this person is verified".

Why "spot the deepfake" is the wrong strategy

Many articles offer lists of visual clues: unnatural blinking, blurred edges around the face, odd lighting, lips out of sync. Some of these clues appear in real cases, and the FBI's 2022 alert mentions mismatched lip movements. [1] But as a defence, a clue list has serious weaknesses.

- **It is a moving target.** Tools improve. A clue that works this year may not next year. Your process should not need updating every time a model does.

- **It produces false alarms.** Poor lighting, a weak connection, a cheap webcam, a stammer, a disability, a different accent or a neurodivergent communication style can all look "off" to someone hunting for oddness. Treating those as signs of fraud is unfair and risks discrimination.
- **It produces false confidence.** If the video "looks fine", people relax. A good fake or a good stand-in will look fine.
- **It depends on the viewer.** A tired manager at 5pm will see less than a fresh one at 9am. Processes do not get tired.
- **It tempts you to rely on a tool.** Commercial "deepfake detectors" exist, but you should not treat any single tool's verdict as proof. The FBI's own advice for these cases stresses combining signals, requiring human review and calibrating controls to limit false positives. [4]

You may still notice something odd. If you do, write it down and treat it as one signal among several (Chapter 10). Just do not make it your whole defence.

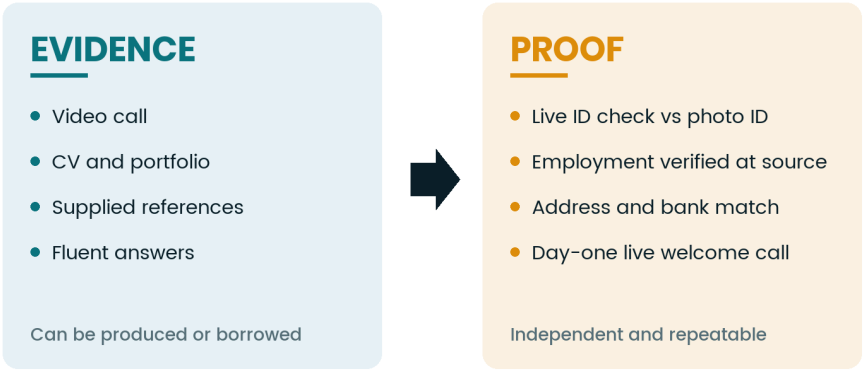
Friction beats detection

A better mental model: **do not try to catch the fake; make the fake expensive.** Every extra step that requires a real, present, verifiable person raises the cost of the fraud and barely inconveniences an honest candidate. Some examples of "friction" recommended in official guidance:

- verifying identity at several points, not once: during interviews, during onboarding and throughout employment [2];
- verifying prior employment and education **directly with the employers and schools involved**, not via contact details supplied by the candidate [3];
- doing as much hiring and onboarding in person as practical [2];

- shipping equipment only to the address on the employee's identification documents, and requiring additional documentation for any alternate address [3];
- withholding system access until background checks are complete [3].

The July 2025 FBI alert also suggests that during virtual interviews you require video with unobscured backgrounds, ask the candidate to show their surroundings, and ask them to wave a hand in front of their face, which may disrupt AI-generated video. [3] Treat these as sensible *friction*, not as a lie detector. They can make a lazy fake stumble, but a failed or passed wave proves nothing on its own, and nobody should be rejected solely on that basis.



Video and documents are evidence. Proof comes from independent verification.

A simple rule for your team

> **The rule.** Video tells you someone is there. It never tells you who they are. Identity is established by independent verification, and the interview is for assessing skills and fit.

Illustrative example

> **Illustrative example.** *Marta* runs a small bookkeeping software firm. Her team interviews a support engineer over video; the candidate is warm, quick and technically sharp. In a debrief, Marta says, "I'm sure they're genuine." Her colleague Ivo asks, "Sure compared with what?" They realise the only evidence is that the candidate sounded confident. They add a rule: after any offer, a live identity check against a government photo ID is done in a separate session, by someone who was not in the interviews, using a method the candidate did not choose. The candidate passes without fuss. The point is not that Marta was wrong. It is that she no longer needs to be right by instinct.

What to tell candidates

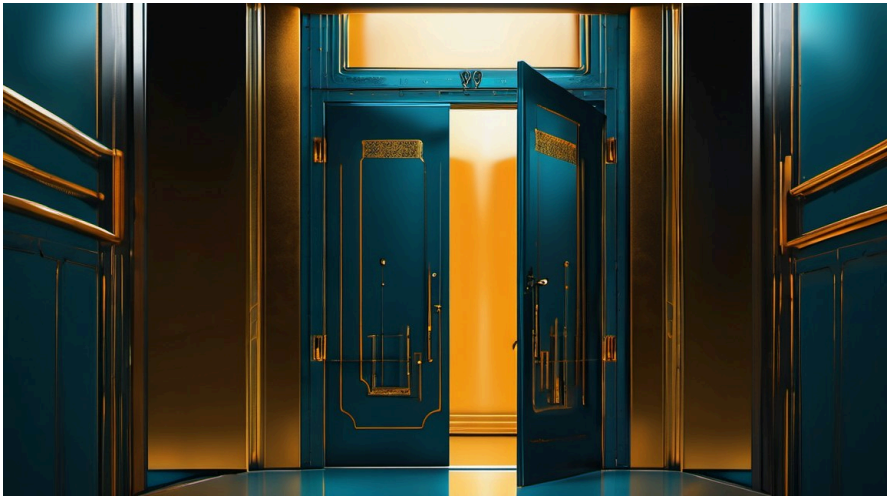
Honest candidates appreciate clarity. Add one line to every job advert and invitation: "We verify identity for all hires. Our process includes a live video call and a document check before an offer is finalised." This sets expectations, deters casual fraud and shows fairness, because everyone is told the same thing.

This week

- ☐ Remove "I could tell they were genuine" from your vocabulary in hiring debriefs. Replace it with "What did we verify, and how?"
- ☐ Add the one-line identity-verification notice to your job advert template and interview invitation.
- ☐ Brief everyone who interviews: video is for assessing skills, not for establishing identity.
- ☐ Agree that nobody is rejected for a poor connection, an accent, a disability-related difference in how they communicate, or an unusual-looking video alone. Anything unusual is noted and passed to the hiring-security owner for a fair follow-up.

CHAPTER 3

The Real Risks After a Bad Hire: Access, Data, Money, and Reputation



The problem you may recognise

You are not sure the effort is worth it. "What is the worst that could happen?" is a fair question, and without an answer, security always loses to the pressure to fill the seat. This chapter makes the downside concrete, so that you can decide how much checking each role deserves.

The risk in plain language

A fraudulent or unverified hire is dangerous mainly because of **what they are allowed to touch**. Think of every new starter as a bundle of permissions. The question is not "is this person nice?" but "what could someone in this seat do, on purpose or by accident, with the access we give them?"

Access to systems

The FBI's alerts and Recorded Future's research describe a consistent pattern: the objective of the fraudulent worker is to obtain employment and then use the employer's equipment, accounts and network. [1][2][5] Typical red flags reported on the employer's side include:

- remote desktop or remote monitoring tools installed on company devices, such as AnyDesk, TeamViewer, RustDesk, Chrome Remote Desktop or Splashtop Streamer; [4]
- hardware that lets a different computer control the company laptop (the FBI names KVM-over-IP devices); [4]
- multiple logins to one account from different countries in a short period; [2]
- company code copied to personal repositories or cloud accounts; [2]
- harvesting of company credentials or session cookies to work from non-company devices. [2]

You do not need to understand the technology behind each one. You need to know that the first line of defence is *not letting a stranger have unrestricted access*, and the second is having someone who would notice if something unusual happened.

Access to data

If your new hire can open customer records, employee files or contracts, then a fraudulent hire can copy them. In Europe and the UK, a personal data breach can trigger notification duties and, for serious failures, regulatory action. Even without a regulator, customers who learn their data was exposed through a hiring failure may take their business elsewhere. (This is general background. Check your own obligations with a qualified adviser. The incident card in Appendix G includes a prompt to consider this early.)

Access to money

Money risks are broader than payroll. Think about who can:

- approve or release payments;
- change supplier bank details;
- issue refunds;
- use company cards;
- submit expense claims;
- see invoices and bank statements.

Recorded Future's report notes that operators pushed payments toward personal bank accounts and used a range of payment platforms. [5] The FBI recommends comparing payment accounts across employees, watching for shared documentation or matching bank details, monitoring frequent bank-account changes and being cautious about paying in virtual currency. [3] For a small business the practical lesson is simple: **payroll details should be verified by someone other than the person submitting them**, and changes should always trigger a check.

Access to intellectual property

For software, design, research or consulting businesses, source code, client deliverables and internal strategy are the crown jewels. The FBI warns of code repositories copied to personal profiles or personal cloud accounts. [2] Recorded Future reports exfiltration of proprietary data, source code and internal communications. [5]

Legal and contractual exposure

Some customers, particularly larger ones, require you to state who has access to their data, where those people are based and how they were vetted. A hire who turns out to be someone else can place you in breach of a customer contract, a security questionnaire answer or a supplier agreement. Likewise, if a hire turns out not to have the right to work, you may face consequences of your own. (Chapter 7 covers right-to-work in the UK context.)

The FBI describes the North Korean IT worker schemes as a way of evading U.S. and U.N. sanctions by earning revenue from private companies. [3] If you ever suspect that wages are going somewhere they should not, that is a matter for a lawyer and the authorities, not for quiet self-help. Take advice early.

Reputation and morale

If a fraudulent hire is discovered, customers, staff and partners will ask why nobody checked. Colleagues may feel deceived. Honest candidates who were rejected in favour of a fake may feel wronged. A small business lives on trust. This is the risk that is hardest to measure and hardest to repair.

A quick way to rate a role

You do not need the same rigour for every position. Give each role a rating based on the **most damaging thing a bad hire could do**.

Level	What the role can reach	Example roles	Verification depth
Low	Little beyond their own tools; no customer data, money or admin rights	Social media assistant, general admin with no data access	Standard checks (Chapter 4–5), identity at offer
Medium	Some customer data, internal systems or limited money movement	Customer support, junior bookkeeper, marketing manager	Add reference verification, document check, staged access
High	Source code, admin consoles, payment approval, bulk customer data, supplier bank details	Developers, IT administrators, finance lead, data analysts	Everything above, plus live identity check, extended probation access, device controls

Write the level next to the job title before you advertise. It keeps the proportionality honest: heavy checks for the roles that could do real harm, lighter checks for the rest.

Illustrative example

> **Illustrative example.** *Northfield Dental Supplies* is an invented 20-person online retailer. It hires a part-time "finance assistant" remotely. The role is rated Medium on paper, but in practice the new starter is given the shared login to the accounting package and the bank's online portal "to save time". Nobody rated the role honestly because nobody wrote the level down. Six weeks later a supplier's bank details change. If the starter was not who they claimed, the company would have just handed over its payment controls on day one. The fix is not clever technology. It is rating the role, then giving the starter only the access that matches that rating, with payment approval left with a second, long-standing person.

The "blast radius" question

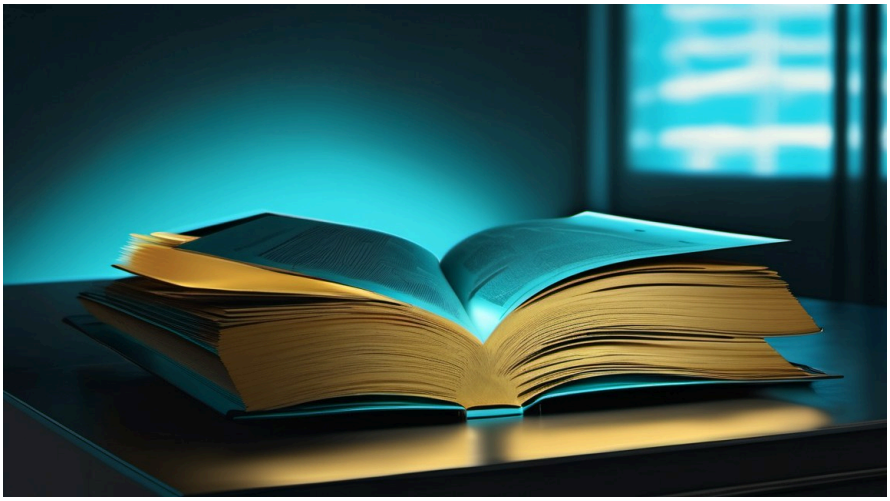
Security professionals use the phrase *blast radius* for how much damage one account can do. Ask it about each role: if this person's account were controlled by a stranger tomorrow, what could they reach, and how quickly would we notice? If the answer worries you, the answer is rarely "interview harder". It is "reduce the access, split the duties, add a second pair of eyes".

This week

- ☐ Rate every role you are currently hiring for as Low, Medium or High and write the rating in the job file.
- ☐ For each High role, list the five most sensitive things that role could access on day one.
- ☐ Check who can approve payments and change supplier bank details. If it is one person with no second check, schedule a fix.
- ☐ Look at the shared logins in your business. Replace them with named accounts wherever you can.

CHAPTER 4

Write Safer Job Ads and Screen Applications Without Creating Bias



The problem you may recognise

You need volume, so you post widely. Your inbox fills with applications, many written in strikingly similar language. You have two bad options: read all of them carefully (no time) or skim for "red flags" you half remember from an article. The second option is where bias creeps in.

The risk in plain language

Hiring fraud and hiring bias are two risks that need to be solved together. A screening rule that catches fakes but systematically excludes real people is a failure. The FBI's own October 2026 alert warns against relying solely on ban lists or name-based filtering,

because they can exclude qualified applicants and harm identity-theft victims. [4] That is a striking statement from a law-enforcement source, and it is the guiding principle of this chapter.

Notice too that some lists of "red flags" in public guidance include items such as claimed education from non-US institutions. [2] A list written for the specific US context of a particular threat should not become your own screening filter. Using a candidate's country of study, nationality, name, accent or age as a shortcut for "probably fake" would be unfair and, in many jurisdictions, unlawful discrimination. Where a signal is risky because it is a proxy for a protected characteristic, use it only to trigger a *neutral, equal* verification step, never to reject.

Write a job ad that does the right things

Your advert is the first security control, and it also shapes who applies.

Describe the work, not the person. Focus on skills, outputs and requirements. Avoid language that restricts by age, gender, nationality or similar characteristics unless there is a genuine legal requirement. If you are in the UK, think about the Equality Act (consult an adviser if unsure).

Be explicit about verification. Include a short, friendly statement such as:

> *"We carry out identity and right-to-work checks for all hires. These are done through a secure process after interview and before any offer is finalised. We apply the same steps to every candidate and will make reasonable adjustments if you need them."*

State your rules on AI assistance. Candidates deserve to know in advance. For example: "You are welcome to use spell-checkers and accessibility tools. In live interviews and technical tests, please do not use AI assistants or have another person help you unless we have agreed it in advance." If your policy differs, state your policy. Clarity makes later decisions fair.

Limit what you ask for at the first stage. Under data-protection principles, collect what you need at each stage and no more. A CV and a short answer to one or two questions are enough to shortlist. Do not ask for ID documents, dates of birth, bank details or a copy of a passport in the initial application. Doing so exposes candidates, and if your inbox is compromised, it exposes you.

Use an official application route. Send applicants to a form or an inbox you control, not a free-for-all of private messages. Be aware that the PurpleDelta research describes operators applying across at least eight recruitment platforms at a rate of at least 60 jobs a day. [5] That is a reason to have a simple, consistent intake.

Do not advertise the sensitivity of your systems. Avoid describing your security tools, your access arrangements or the exact data the role will touch in a public advert.

Screen applications fairly

Before reading any applications, write down your **shortlisting criteria**: three to six job-related requirements, such as "two or more years working with X", "has delivered Y". Use the same criteria for all. This is more fair and also helps you recognise anomalies, because you are comparing against a standard, not a mood.

Then use a short **consistency check** on the applications you intend to shortlist. This is not a rejection test; it is a prompt for follow-up.

Check	What you are looking for	How to be fair
Duplicate content	The same, or near-identical, CV wording, phone number or email appearing under different names. The FBI recommends cross-checking HR systems for applicants with matching résumé content or contact information and reviewing for reused phone numbers (especially VoIP) and email addresses. [2]	Duplicates are a signal to verify, not proof. Two real candidates may share a CV template.
Timeline logic	Do dates, job titles and locations fit together? Does experience match the claimed seniority?	Allow for career breaks, caring, illness and study without penalty.
Public presence	Do professional profiles exist, with a history that fits the CV?	Many excellent people have a small online footprint. Absence alone is not a red flag.
Reference of contact details	Are the contact details for referees on real organisation domains rather than free webmail?	Self-employed and freelance referees may legitimately use personal emails. Ask for more information, not rejection.
Application behaviour	Instant, templated replies, requests to move quickly to a messaging app, reluctance to use your normal channel	A candidate may simply prefer a different channel. Offer your standard route and see how they respond.

The consistency check should be done by someone trained to do it the same way for every shortlisted candidate. Record what was checked and the outcome, using neutral language.

Beware of what you automate

Applicant tracking systems and AI screening tools promise to save time. Use them carefully. The ICO's draft guidance on recruitment and selection, which was still marked as draft and subject to change

at the time of research, includes a dedicated section on automated decision-making and profiling for recruitment, as well as on verifying candidates and keeping recruitment records. [7] The practical advice: do not let software alone reject candidates; keep a human in the loop; understand what the tool does with candidates' data; and check with a data-protection adviser before adopting any tool that profiles applicants.

One more irony: if your own screening tool is trained to favour polished, keyword-rich CVs, it is rewarding exactly what AI-written CVs deliver. A shortlist built purely on polish is easier to game.

Handling candidate data safely

Applications contain personal data. Keep it in one controlled place, restrict who can see it, and set a retention period so you do not keep unsuccessful candidates' details longer than needed. The ICO's draft guidance includes a section on keeping recruitment records. [7] Decide your own retention period with your adviser and write it down. Tell candidates in a short privacy notice what you collect and why.

Illustrative example

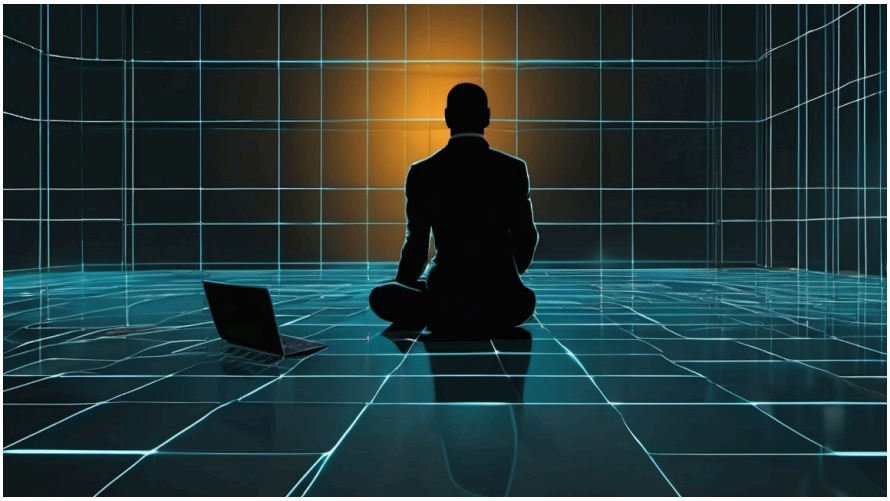
> **Illustrative example.** *Brightwave Learning* is an invented 9-person e-learning company hiring a remote course developer. Instead of reading 120 CVs ad hoc, the founder, Aisha, writes five shortlisting criteria, scores each CV against them, and then runs the consistency check on her top eight. Two CVs turn out to share the same phone number and near-identical "key achievements" paragraphs. She does not reject them. She invites both to the same standard video interview and the same identity check as everyone else. One candidate completes it without issue (the shared paragraph came from a CV-writing service they both used). The other stops replying. Aisha did not need to guess, accuse or profile anyone; the process did the sorting.

This week

- ☐ Add your verification statement and AI-assistance rule to your standard job advert.
- ☐ Write 3–6 job-related shortlisting criteria for your next role *before* you open the applications.
- ☐ Create a one-page consistency checklist (Appendix B) and use it on every shortlisted candidate.
- ☐ Check what your recruiting software does with candidate data and whether it makes automated rejections. Turn off automatic rejection if it is on.
- ☐ Agree a retention period for unsuccessful applications and put it in your privacy notice.

CHAPTER 5

A Better First Interview: Questions, Verification, and Red Flags



The problem you may recognise

Your interviews are conversational. You like candidates to feel at ease, so you ask open questions and follow your curiosity. That is good for rapport and poor for security, because a fluent, rehearsed or AI-fed candidate can sail through a friendly chat. You also vary your questions between candidates, which makes it hard to compare answers or notice patterns.

The risk in plain language

A video interview is where two jobs get tangled: *assessing skills* and *establishing identity*. Keep them apart. In the interview, your goals are to understand the candidate's real experience and to see how they think. Identity is verified separately, with documents and

independent checks (Chapter 7). The interview can, however, be designed so that borrowed answers, scripted responses and stand-ins find it harder to hide.

Structure the interview

Use the same core questions for every candidate for the role. Write them in advance. Structured interviews are fairer because every candidate meets the same standard, and they make deviations easier to spot.

Ask for specifics, not slogans. Fraudulent or AI-assisted answers often sound generic. Honest experts can usually go deep on something they did. Ask:

- "Tell me about a project from your CV that you personally built. What was the hardest decision you made?"
- "What did you get wrong the first time, and how did you find out?"
- "Walk me through the last time you had to explain this to a non-specialist."
- "What would you do differently now?"

Then ask two or three follow-up questions about their own answer, especially about trade-offs, mistakes, people and constraints. Real experience has texture: awkward colleagues, tight deadlines, odd client requests. A scripted or chatbot-supplied answer tends to be smooth and bloodless. Recorded Future's research found operators repeating chatbot-generated answers verbatim, even when they were wrong. [5] Follow-ups expose that, but never treat a single weak answer as proof of fraud. Nerves are real.

Include an unscripted moment. Ask something that cannot easily be pre-answered: "Share your screen and show me where you would start debugging this", or "Talk me through how you would set up the

first week for a customer who just signed." Give them a few minutes to think aloud.

Watch for latency, not looks. You are not hunting for visual glitches. Notice instead whether there is a consistent delay between your question and the start of the answer, whether the candidate reads rather than speaks, whether they ask you to repeat questions in a way that buys time. These are *weak* signals that can also be nerves, a poor connection or a language difference. Note them; do not act on any one.

Do the verification steps built into the call

Chapter 2 explained that the video itself is not proof. But you can use the call to gather *useful, fair* friction.

1. **Camera on, background visible.** Ask all candidates to join with their camera on, in a space that is reasonably clear. The FBI recommends requiring video with unobscured backgrounds and having candidates show their surroundings. [3] Offer a quiet alternative for anyone who has privacy or safety concerns, such as a shared home, a disability or a caring responsibility, and make that adjustment available to everyone who asks.
2. **A natural movement.** The FBI suggests asking the person to wave a hand in front of their face, which may disrupt AI-generated video. [3] If you use it, make it part of a general "let's check the video is working" moment for everybody, and treat any anomaly as a trigger for a follow-up, never as a verdict.
3. **Consistent person across rounds.** The FBI recommends capturing images of individuals to compare across meetings, since the person interviewing may differ from the person doing the work. [3] Capturing images raises data-protection questions. Instead, a low-risk approach is to assign one person to confirm at each later stage "this looks like the same person we met" and record yes or no, and to rely on the live ID comparison at offer

stage. If you want to record or screenshot interviews, tell candidates in advance, explain why, and check data-protection rules with an adviser first.

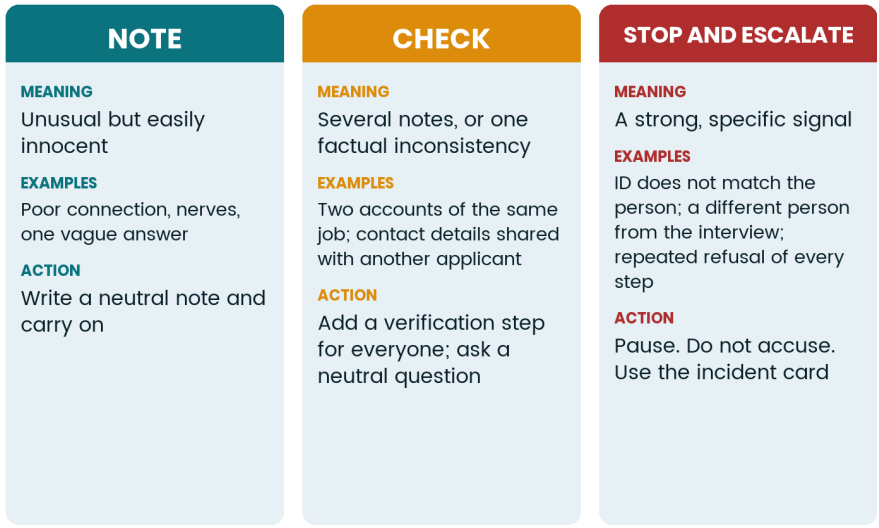
4. **Location questions, asked fairly.** The FBI suggests asking "soft" questions about location and background. [2] Make these natural and the same for everyone: "Which time zone will you be working in?", "Will you be working from home or a shared space?", "Where would you be receiving equipment?" The answers should be consistent with the rest of the file. Do not ask about nationality, immigration status, age, family plans or health during interviews.
5. **Look at the screen-share, not the person.** In a technical interview, a live screen share of their own environment tells you more than their face. Pay attention to remote-access software, a second device, or a delay between your question and the keyboard.

Red flags: how to use them properly

A red flag is a reason to look more closely, not a reason to reject. The FBI's October 2026 alert says that no single indicator reliably identifies these workers and recommends treating moderate or weak indicators as grounds for enhanced scrutiny when combined, with substantive human review. [4] Use a three-level system.

Level	Meaning	Examples	What to do
Note	Something unusual but easily innocent	Poor connection; mild nerves; vague answer to one question	Write a neutral note; carry on
Check	Several notes, or one factual inconsistency	Two different accounts of the same job; refusal to turn on the camera with no reason given; phone number or email also appearing on another application	Add a verification step from Appendix A; ask a neutral clarifying question

Level	Meaning	Examples	What to do
Stop and escalate	A strong, specific signal that the person may not be who they say	Identity document does not match the person; the candidate who interviewed is clearly different from the one who joins; a coached or supplied voice is evident; repeated refusal of every identity step	Pause; do not accuse; follow the incident card (Appendix G)



The Note, Check, Stop-and-escalate scale.

Signals reported in official or research sources

These are drawn from published sources about remote-hiring fraud. None is proof. None should be used alone.

- Lip movements that do not match audio, or sounds that do not match the action on screen. [1]
- Use of face-swapping or AI during video interviews. [2]
- Reused phone numbers (especially VoIP) or email addresses across several applications. [2]
- Typos or unusual wording in résumés. [2]
- Changes to address or payment details during onboarding. [2]

- Requests to ship equipment to an address other than the one on the identification documents. [3]
- Requests to move communication away from the platform where the work or application began. [5]

Signals that are not red flags

- A strong or unfamiliar accent.
- Studying or working in another country.
- Not having a large social media presence.
- A nervous manner, a long pause, or needing a question repeated.
- A background that is blurred for privacy.
- Not owning a modern laptop or having an unreliable connection.
- A non-traditional career path.

The second list matters. If your team starts reading these as warning signs, you will be unfair to genuine candidates, and you will miss real fraud because you are looking in the wrong places.

Scripts for awkward moments

Most interviewers freeze at the same few moments. Having the words ready makes you calmer and fairer.

When the camera is off. *"We ask everyone to have their camera on for this stage, so we can have a proper conversation. Is there something that makes that difficult? If so, tell me and we'll find an alternative, such as a different time or a short call in a quieter place."* Listen to the answer. Plenty of people have good reasons. Note what was said, then offer the alternative.

When an answer seems rehearsed. *"That's a clear summary. Could you take me through one specific moment, such as what you were doing that week and who else was involved?"*

When there is a long pause. *"Take your time. I'll rephrase the question."* Then rephrase it in plain words. Do not fill silence with hints.

When you suspect a second person is helping. Do not accuse. Say: *"To keep the conversation fair for everyone, could you confirm that you're on your own on this call and not using any assistants?"* Ask every candidate the same thing at the start, so nobody is singled out.

When the candidate asks why you verify identity. *"We do it for everyone we hire. It protects you from someone borrowing your identity, and it protects us from hiring someone who isn't who they say they are."* Most people nod and move on.

When the candidate pushes back on a step. *"I understand. What would make it easier for you? We can offer another route that gives us the same assurance."* The question is not whether they like the step. The question is whether they will complete an equivalent one.

Be transparent and kind

Tell candidates up front what to expect: "This is a video interview. We ask everyone to have their camera on. After interview, if you are our preferred candidate, we will ask for a short identity check." Honest candidates relax when they know the shape of the process. If someone has a legitimate difficulty with any step, offer an alternative that gives you equivalent assurance.

Illustrative example

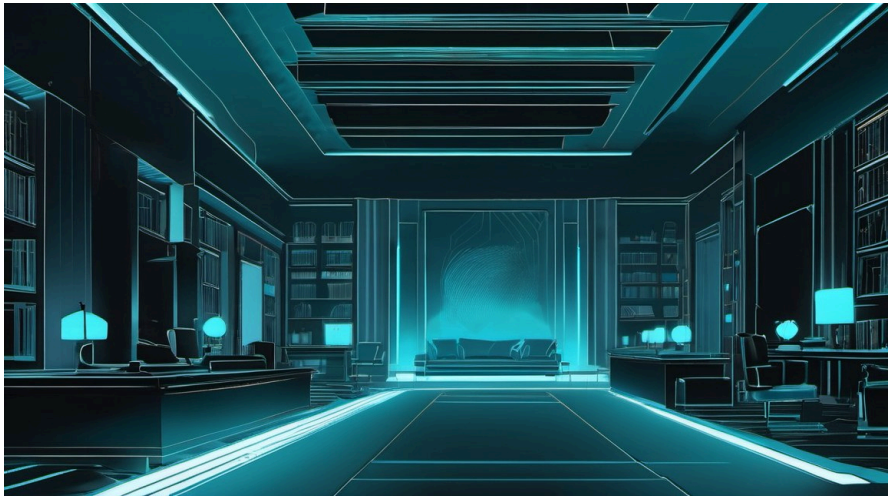
> **Illustrative example.** *Tomás*, an IT manager at an invented 30-person legal services firm, interviews a candidate for a systems administrator role. The candidate's first answer is textbook-perfect but when Tomás asks about the last outage they handled, the answer shifts between two stories. He doesn't challenge. He notes "inconsistent detail on outage story" and asks the same follow-up he asks everyone: "What did the post-incident review conclude?" The candidate says they need to check. Tomás logs a *Check*, not a *Stop*. At the second interview, a colleague asks a different technical question, and the candidate gives a confident, detailed answer that fits the CV. The first interview was a bad day; the file is balanced, and the candidate proceeds to the identity check like everyone else.

This week

- ☐ Write 5–8 core interview questions for your next role. Ask them of every candidate.
- ☐ Add 3 follow-up probes ("What went wrong? What would you do differently? Who disagreed?").
- ☐ Adopt the video-interview protocol (Appendix C) and tell candidates what to expect in the invitation.
- ☐ Give everyone who interviews the Note / Check / Stop-and-escalate table, and the "not a red flag" list.
- ☐ Decide who in your business receives a "Check" escalation.

CHAPTER 6

Safe Technical Tests, Portfolios, References, and Recruitment Agencies



The problem you may recognise

You want proof that people can do the work, so you give a take-home test, review a portfolio and call two referees. You also use an agency now and then, because your own time is limited. Each of these is a legitimate, standard practice. Each is also a way for a determined person to substitute someone else or to use tools you did not expect.

The risk in plain language

There are two separate dangers.

Danger 1: the test measures the wrong person or tool. A take-home exercise can be done by anyone, with any assistant. A portfolio can be built from others' work. A reference can be written by a friend.

Danger 2: the test itself exposes you. A badly designed test might give an unknown applicant access to your real systems, real data or real customers.

The fix is to design assessments that test real ability under conditions you control and that never expose anything sensitive.

Technical tests: a safer pattern

1. Use synthetic or sanitised material only. Never give candidates real customer data, real credentials, production access or confidential code. Create a small fictional dataset or a stripped-down sample project for the test. If you would be uncomfortable seeing the test files posted online, do not use them.

2. Prefer a short live exercise to a long take-home. A 45-minute live session where the candidate shares their screen and thinks aloud is harder to outsource than a weekend project, and it gives you a second look at how they work. If a take-home is useful, keep it short and pair it with a live walkthrough: "Talk us through your decisions, and now change this part live."

3. Make the follow-up the real test. After any take-home, ask the candidate to explain it and to modify it live. The explanation shows whether they understood what they submitted.

4. State your AI and tools rules in writing. Some employers welcome AI assistance because the job will involve it; some forbid it for the test. Either can be fair, as long as everyone is told the same rule beforehand and the test fits what the job requires. If assistance is allowed, change what you assess: judgment, review, explanation, correction of errors, not raw output.

5. Do not install anything on a candidate's device or ask them to install your software on a personal device. Ask them to use their own tools in a sandbox or a browser-based environment you control. Equally, do not accept requests for you to install remote-access tools or screen-control software on your device.

6. Do not give candidates access to your accounts. No shared logins. No invitation to your cloud console, repository or chat workspace until after the offer stage and identity verification. If a practical exercise needs a repository, create a throwaway one with no link to your real organisation.

7. Keep a copy of the test and the output. Store them with the candidate's file for as long as your retention period allows. If something is later disputed, you have evidence.

8. Pay fairly where tests are long. A long unpaid assignment is both an equity concern and an invitation to cut corners. A short, bounded test is fairer for everybody.

Reviewing what comes back

Do not decide on the code or document alone. Combine the work product with the interview, the follow-up and the references. Watch for these signals:

- the candidate cannot explain parts of their own submission;
- the style differs radically from their live work;
- the solution contains obvious generic boilerplate or comments that do not fit the problem;
- the candidate resists a live modification of their own work.

As with all signals, one is a conversation, several together are a reason to verify.

Portfolios and public work

A portfolio proves that *someone made* the work, not that the candidate did. Verify authorship in ways that are cheap and polite.

- Ask the candidate to pick **one** piece and describe their specific contribution, the people involved and what changed after launch.
- Where the work is public (code in a repository, writing under a byline), check that **the account's history** supports the claim: when it started, whether the contributions are consistent, whether collaborators exist.
- Where the work is client work under NDA, ask the candidate to describe it at a level that does not breach confidentiality, and verify through the reference process.
- Accept that talented people may have little public work. Do not penalise them. Use a live exercise instead.

The FBI advises cross-referencing photos and contact details with social media, portfolios and payment platforms. [3] Consistency across independent sources is the point, not any single profile.

References that actually verify

A reference supplied by the candidate and contacted at an address the candidate gave you is a weak control. The better pattern is **independent verification** (Appendix E has a script).

1. **Find the organisation's contact details yourself.** Use the company's official website or switchboard, not the email or phone number on the CV.
2. **Verify employment first.** Confirm with HR or a manager that the person worked there, in that role, for those dates. The FBI recommends verifying prior employment and education directly with the employers and schools involved. [3]
3. **Then ask for the reference.** Use the same short set of questions for each referee.

4. **Be wary of speed and sameness.** Instant, glowing replies from webmail addresses, or references written in the same style as the candidate's CV, deserve a second look. The FBI recommends reviewing communication accounts for reused phone numbers and email addresses across résumés. [2]
5. **Speak, don't just email, for High roles.** A short call lets you hear hesitations and ask follow-ups.
6. **Respect privacy.** Contact referees only with the candidate's permission, and say who will be contacted. Contacting a current employer before an offer can put a candidate's job at risk; always ask first.

What if a candidate cannot provide traditional references? They may be self-employed, new to the workforce, or returning from a break. Offer alternatives: a previous client, a lecturer, a collaborator on an open project, a professional body that can confirm membership. Fairness means allowing equivalent proof, not insisting on one form.

Recruitment agencies and staffing firms

Agencies reduce workload but add a link in the chain that you do not control. The FBI notes that companies using third-party IT vendors face added risk because they are removed from the direct hiring process, and advises confirming that third-party staffing firms have robust hiring practices and auditing them routinely. [2][3] Recorded Future lists staffing and consulting among the sectors targeted. [5]

Ask your agency, in writing:

- What identity checks do you carry out, and when? Are they live, and are they done against government documents?
- Do you verify employment and education directly with the source?
- Do you ever allow a different person to attend an interview from the one who will do the work?

- Where will the worker be located, and where will equipment be sent?
- Do you subcontract any part of the work?
- What happens if you discover a worker was not who they claimed?

Then add a contract term or an email confirmation that the **person you interview is the person who will work**, that substitution requires your written approval, and that you may verify identity yourself at onboarding.

Where an agency supplies a contractor, you still decide what access they receive. Chapter 9 explains how.

Illustrative example

> **Illustrative example.** *Kestrel Analytics*, an invented 25-person data consultancy, sets a four-hour take-home task using a realistic but fictional dataset. A candidate returns an excellent solution. In the live follow-up, the hiring manager asks the candidate to change one assumption and rerun the analysis. The candidate struggles to find the part of the code they "wrote". The manager does not accuse the candidate. She notes the gap, asks about how the work was done, and moves to the standard references step. The referees, contacted through the companies' main numbers, both confirm the candidate worked there, but one cannot recall the candidate's specific projects. Taken together, the file no longer supports an offer. Notice that no one was accused of anything: the process produced enough clear evidence for a calm decision.

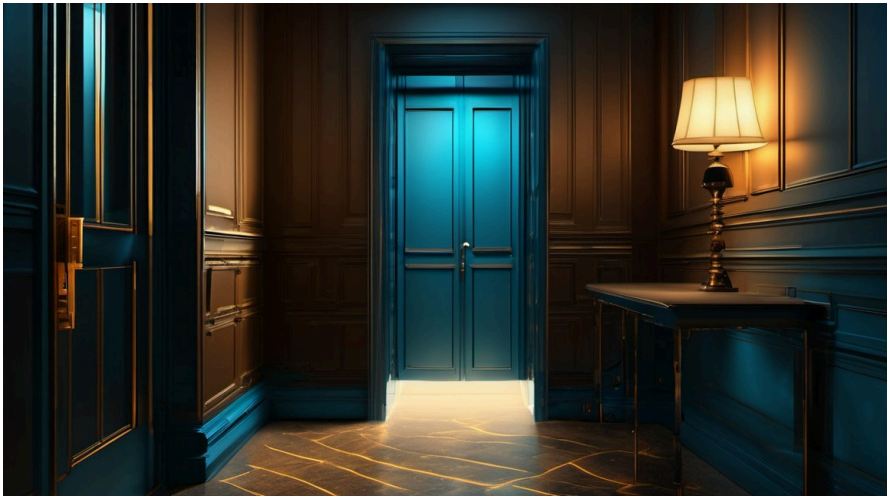
This week

- ☐ Replace any test that uses real data or real accounts with a synthetic exercise.

- ☐ Add a live follow-up to every take-home test ("explain it; now change it").
- ☐ Write your AI-use rule for tests and put it in the instructions.
- ☐ Adopt the reference script (Appendix E). Source contact details yourself.
- ☐ Send your recruitment agency the six questions above and ask for written answers.

CHAPTER 7

Fair Identity and Right-to-Work Verification: What Small Businesses Need to Consider



The problem you may recognise

You know you should check ID. You are not sure how, what is legally allowed, what to keep, or whether asking for a passport scan over email is a good idea. You worry about getting it wrong in either direction: being too lax and hiring a fraud, or being too intrusive and breaking data-protection or equality rules.

Note: this chapter explains the general approach and uses UK sources as its main example. It is not legal advice. Rules differ by country and change, so confirm current requirements with an adviser or the official guidance for your jurisdiction.

The risk in plain language

There are three different things people call "ID checks", and mixing them up causes most of the confusion.

1. **Identity verification**: is this person who they say they are? (A fraud-prevention question.)
2. **Right-to-work verification**: are they legally allowed to take this job in this country? (A legal-compliance question.)
3. **Background screening**: criminal-record, credit, qualification or sanctions checks. (A role-specific, legally constrained question.)

They overlap, but they are not the same, and each has its own rules. In this chapter we focus on the first two.

Principles that keep you on the right side

Proportionate. Do the amount of checking the role justifies. A High-risk role (Chapter 3) warrants a live document check and independent verification; a Low-risk role may not.

Necessary and minimal. Collect only the data you need, at the stage you need it. Avoid collecting ID from every applicant; do it for the person you intend to hire.

Equal. Ask every candidate for the same type of evidence at the same stage. Do not choose who to check based on how someone looks, sounds or what their name is. The FBI's October 2026 alert warns against relying solely on name-based filtering and ban lists. [4]

Transparent. Tell people what you will ask for, why, how you will keep it, and for how long.

Secure. Never ask candidates to email photographs of passports, driving licences or similar documents. Use a secure upload, an in-person check or a certified provider, and restrict who can see the result.

Accessible. Provide reasonable alternatives for people who cannot complete a particular method, for instance because of disability, lack of a smartphone or lack of a specific document. Offer an equivalent route rather than ending the process.

Right to work in the UK: a brief orientation

Check the official guidance. This summarises what the sources said at the time of research.

GOV.UK's guidance for employers says that you must check that a person has the right to work for you in the UK **before they start**, and that a time-limited right must be rechecked when it is due to expire. [9] The main methods described are:

- **Online check using a share code**, for people who can get one. British and Irish citizens cannot get a share code. [9]
- **Digital checks using an identity service provider** using identity document validation technology. [9]
- **Manual check** of original documents in the presence of the applicant, with copies kept. [9]
- If a person cannot show documents but has an outstanding application or appeal, an employer can ask the Home Office to confirm status and keep the **Positive Verification Notice**. [9]

On record-keeping, GOV.UK says to keep clear, unalterable copies, record the date of the check, and keep copies during employment and for two years after the employee leaves. It also states you must not discriminate against anyone based on where they are from. [9]

An updated employer's guide, dated 1 October 2026, is published on GOV.UK. [10] Commentary from the sector indicates changes to digital right-to-work checks around that date, including requirements concerning registered digital verification providers and the disclosure of which provider is performing a check where a reseller or platform is involved. I have not independently confirmed

those details in the final text, so read the current guide itself, or ask your payroll provider or adviser which methods you are permitted to use. [10]

Two practical consequences for small businesses:

1. **A right-to-work check is not a fraud check.** A genuine document held by an impostor, or a real person's details used by someone else, can pass a document-only check if nobody confirms the person in front of you matches the photo. For remote hires, use a method that includes a live link between the person and the document, such as a certified digital check that matches a live face to the document, or a manual check carried out with the person present on a live video call and following the current rules for your jurisdiction.
2. **Do the check before they start, and keep the file.** Chapter 8 covers why the gap between offer and start date is a vulnerable moment.

Outside the UK

Rules differ. In many EU countries, right-to-work, identity and employment-registration processes are national and involve different authorities, and local law sets what data you can collect. In the United States, the I-9 process and E-Verify are the relevant federal mechanisms; the FBI alert mentions E-Verify and requiring multiple forms of identification among ways to add verification friction. [4] Whatever your country, the principles above apply: proportionate, equal, minimal, secure, and documented.

Using technology to compare a face to an ID

Many identity-verification services compare a live selfie to the photo on a document. This is effective, but it processes **biometric data**, which in UK and EU data-protection law is generally treated as special-category data when used to uniquely identify someone, and

so carries stricter conditions. The ICO's employment guidance hub includes material on monitoring workers and biometric data. [8] Before adopting any such tool:

- ask the provider what data is collected, where it is stored, how long, and who sees it;
- check whether you need a data-protection impact assessment;
- offer a non-biometric alternative, such as a human-assisted check, for candidates who object or who cannot use the technology;
- keep only the result and the minimum evidence you need, not a library of faces;
- add the provider to your list of suppliers and your privacy notice.

If that sounds like a lot for a small firm, there is a simple option: use a human check. A trained person compares the candidate on a live video call with the photo on an original document held up to the camera, and records that they did so, using a defined procedure (Appendix C). It is not perfect, but it is proportionate for many Medium roles and when combined with independent verification of employment and education it is a strong layer.

Verification layers: put them in order

For a High-risk role, a sensible sequence looks like this:

Stage	What happens	Why it matters
Application	CV and short answers only	Minimal data
Interview	Structured questions; consistency notes	Skills and fit
Shortlist	Reference and employment verification through independently sourced contacts	Confirms history
Preferred candidate	Live identity check against government photo ID (certified digital or live human-assisted)	Confirms the person
Offer	Offer conditional on right-to-work, references and identity	Keeps leverage

Stage	What happens	Why it matters
Pre-start	Right-to-work check complete; address and payment details verified	Closes the gap
Day one	A short live "welcome call", camera on, to confirm the person who starts is the person you verified	Links identity to access
Weeks 1–4	Staged access; re-verification of any changed details	Limits harm

For a Low-risk role you might collapse some of these, but the principle of **verify before trust** remains.



Verification from application to week four. Steps 4 and 7 link a verified identity to the person who receives access.

What to do if someone cannot or will not comply

An honest candidate sometimes cannot complete a step. They might have no passport, be in a country where particular documents are unavailable, or be uncomfortable with a selfie check. The right response is to offer an alternative route that gives equivalent assurance, not to reject.

If someone refuses *every* reasonable route and gives no explanation, record that neutrally and follow Chapter 10. Do not speculate about their reasons.

Illustrative example

> **Illustrative example.** *Greenway Mobile Repairs*, an invented 18-person business with a remote customer-service team, plans to hire a new agent. The owner, Priya, used to ask candidates to email a passport photo. After reading the guidance, she moves to a secure upload link from her HR system and limits access to two people. She asks every preferred candidate for the same document types, offers a video-call check with a trained colleague as an alternative to an app-based selfie check, and documents each decision. A candidate who is hesitant about the app does the video-call route in ten minutes. Priya keeps the right-to-work evidence in line with the official retention guidance and deletes the identity-check images after verification, as her privacy notice states.

This week

- ☐ Decide which ID method you will use for which risk level, and write it down.
- ☐ Stop accepting identity documents by ordinary email. Set up a secure upload or an in-person or live-video check.

- ☐ Read the current right-to-work guidance for your country. In the UK, start with GOV.UK. [9][10]
- ☐ Add an "alternative route" sentence to your verification instructions for candidates.
- ☐ Write your retention rule for identity and right-to-work evidence, and put it in your privacy notice.

CHAPTER 8

The Offer-to-Onboarding Security Gap



The problem you may recognise

The interviews are done and everyone is happy. You send an offer. Over the next two weeks, the candidate replies with their bank details, a delivery address for the laptop, and a preferred start date. HR sets up accounts so that "everything is ready on day one". This is the stretch of the process where nobody is looking closely, because the hiring decision feels finished.

The risk in plain language

For a fraudulent hire, the gap between *offer* and *first working day* is where the plan is put into action. The FBI's 2025 alert lists "changes to address or payment platforms during onboarding" among its red flags. [2] Its July 2025 alert recommends shipping equipment only to the address on the employee's identification documents, requiring

additional documentation for alternate addresses, comparing payment accounts, and not granting system access until background checks are complete. [3] Recorded Future describes facilitators who receive, configure and maintain company laptops, with remote desktop tools, and recommends that employers do not ship devices to post boxes or to anyone other than the named employee. [5]

In short, the three risk points in this window are:

1. **Where the laptop goes.**
2. **Where the money goes.**
3. **What accounts exist before anyone has verified the person.**

The conditional offer

Make every offer **conditional** on completion of verification. A simple clause does the work:

> *"This offer is conditional on satisfactory completion of identity verification, right-to-work checks, reference verification and, where applicable, any role-specific background checks. You will not receive access to company systems until these are complete."*

This sets expectations, gives you the right to pause without drama, and avoids the awkward position of withdrawing an unconditional offer. Check the wording with an employment adviser.

A six-step bridge from offer to day one

Step 1: Complete verification before shipping anything. The FBI recommends not granting system access until background checks are complete. [3] Hold the laptop and accounts until identity, right-to-work and references are done.

Step 2: Confirm the address from an independent source. Match the delivery address to the one on the verified identity document or proof of address you were shown through your secure process. If the candidate asks for a different address, such as a friend, a parcel locker or a new flat, treat that as a request for **extra verification**, not an automatic refusal. Ask for supporting evidence, and consider handing the device over in person or via a courier that needs a signature from the verified individual.

Step 3: Verify bank details with a second check. Compare the account name to the verified name. The FBI advises comparing payment accounts across employees to find shared documentation or matching bank details. [3] If a new hire's details match another employee's, stop and investigate. Do not accept payment into a third party's account, and be cautious about virtual-currency arrangements. [3]

Step 4: Prepare accounts, but do not activate them. IT can create the account and group memberships in advance, but leave it disabled or restricted until a "go" is given by a named person once all checks are green.

Step 5: Ship and track securely. Use a trackable service with a signature on delivery. Do not leave a high-value laptop with a neighbour. Where possible, pre-configure the device with management software so you can see it enrol.

Step 6: A day-one welcome call. On the first morning, have a short live video call with the new starter. Camera on. They confirm their name, show the same ID used in verification (or a quick re-verify), and a manager from the hiring team confirms that this is the person they met. This links the verified identity to the person who is about to receive access.

Device handling: practical rules

- Use company-managed devices for roles with sensitive access. Avoid "bring your own device" for High roles.
- Enrol devices in management software before they are used.
- Block the installation of remote-access software unless IT approves it. The FBI recommends restricting installation of remote desktop applications and disabling local administrator accounts. [2]
- Record serial numbers, the person it was issued to and the shipping address.
- Ask new starters to sign a short equipment acknowledgment, including that the device must not be used by anyone else and that remote-control tools must not be installed.
- Do not let the first login happen on a personal device with company credentials.

Payroll details

Keep payroll set-up separate from IT access. The person who enters bank details should not be the person who approves them. If a new hire changes their bank details in the first months, call them on a number you already hold (not one from the email requesting the change) and confirm. The FBI recommends monitoring employees who frequently change bank accounts. [3]

Messages you can copy

When sending the conditional offer. *"We're delighted to offer you the role of [title], subject to the conditions in the attached letter. Before your start date we will carry out identity, right-to-work and reference checks, the same for every new starter. We'll send you a secure link and explain each step. If any step is difficult for you, tell us and we'll offer an alternative. Your equipment and system access will be arranged once the checks are complete."*

When the candidate asks for a different delivery address. *"Thanks for letting us know. For security we send equipment to the address on your verified documents. If you need it sent elsewhere, we'll need a short piece of supporting evidence, or we can arrange for you to collect it or sign for it in person. Which would suit you?"*

When bank details change after submission. *"Thanks. As we do for all changes to payment details, I'll confirm this by phone using the number on your file. When is a good time to call?"*

When verification is not complete by the start date. *"We want you to start with everything in place, so we're moving your start date by a few days while we finish the final checks. We'll confirm the new date as soon as they're complete. Thank you for your patience."*

A note on tone

Some candidates will find extra steps unusual. Use friendly, matter-of-fact language: "We do the same for everyone; it protects you and us." Most honest people will agree readily. If someone becomes angry, evasive or vanishes at the point where verification becomes concrete, treat that as one signal, and apply Chapter 10.

Illustrative example

Illustrative example. *Oakridge Surveying*, an invented 40-person firm, hires a GIS analyst remotely. Two days before the start date, the candidate asks to change the delivery address "because the courier says my building has no signature option", and to have pay sent to a different account "because my own bank is slow". Two changes in two days, each plausible. The HR coordinator, Dev, applies the bridge: he asks for evidence of the new address, calls the number from the verified file to confirm the bank change, and holds access. The candidate supplies a utility bill and a bank letter in their own name within a day, and the hire proceeds. In a different version of the story, the answers would have been vague. Either way, nothing sensitive was shipped or enabled until the evidence arrived.

This week

- ☐ Add the conditional-offer wording to your offer template and check it with an adviser.
- ☐ Write a rule: laptops ship only to the verified address; any change triggers a documented extra check.
- ☐ Separate who enters and who approves payroll bank details.
- ☐ Schedule a standard day-one welcome call on camera for every remote starter.
- ☐ Ask IT to prepare accounts in a disabled state until a named person gives the go-ahead.

CHAPTER 9

Contractors, Remote Workers, Devices, and Privileged Access



The problem you may recognise

Your team is not only employees. You use freelancers, short-term contractors, agency staff and an outsourced IT supplier. People join a shared chat on their first morning, and a "temporary" admin account created for a project is still active two years later. Nobody can say, with confidence, who has access to what.

The risk in plain language

Verification at the door only helps if what is behind the door is sensible. Even a fully verified person can make a mistake, be compromised or leave. And contractors are often where checks are thinnest. The FBI's July 2025 alert says that contract IT work is a common way for North Korean IT workers to obtain employment, that companies that outsource IT to third-party vendors face added

risk, and that those vendors should be sent the guidance. [3] The sensible response is **least privilege**: every person gets the minimum access they need to do their job, for as long as they need it.

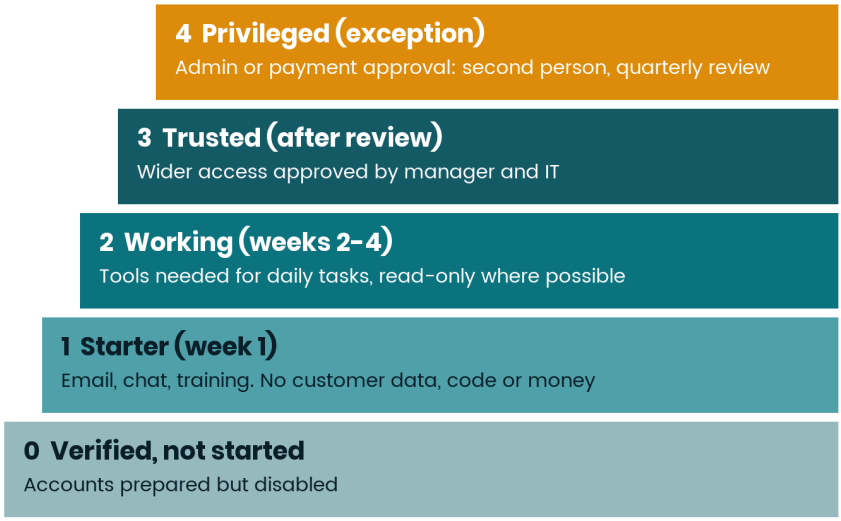
Four ideas that do most of the work

1. Staged access

Trust is earned in steps. Replace "everything on day one" with a ladder.

Stage	Typical timing	Access
0: Verified, not started	Pre-start	None. Accounts prepared but disabled
1: Starter	Week 1	Email, chat, training, role documentation; no customer data, no production, no money
2: Working	Weeks 2–4	The specific tools and data needed for day-to-day tasks, with read-only where possible
3: Trusted	After probation review	Wider access as the role requires, approved by a manager and IT
4: Privileged	By exception	Admin rights, payment approval, bulk data export; approved by a second person, reviewed every quarter

A starter who needs more access can ask. A decision to grant it is recorded and reviewed.



The access ladder. Trust is released in stages.

2. Least privilege and separation of duties

For each role, write a short list called "**needs, may need, never needs**".

- *Needs*: tools without which they cannot work.
- *May need*: access granted on request, with a reason and an end date.
- *Never needs*: things that would be a problem if they had them (for example, a support agent does not need access to payroll).

Where the damage from one person could be large, split the job so it takes two. One person raises a payment; another approves it. One person changes a supplier's bank details; another confirms by phone. The aim is not to distrust staff; it is to make sure one compromised account cannot do everything.

3. Strong sign-in

Turn on multi-factor authentication for every account that supports it, and require it for everyone, not just administrators. The NCSC's Cyber Essentials scheme is a government-backed scheme designed

to help organisations of any size protect against common cyber attacks, and its requirements include controls on user accounts, access and sign-in. [12] The NCSC also offers a free Cyber Action Toolkit aimed at smaller organisations. [11] Use named, individual accounts. Shared logins make it impossible to say who did what.

4. Device control

For any role beyond Low, use company-managed devices. In addition to the controls in Chapter 8:

- Block or alert on remote-access and remote-management tools you did not install. The FBI's October 2026 alert lists tools such as AnyDesk, TeamViewer, RustDesk, Chrome Remote Desktop and Splashtop Streamer, along with KVM-over-IP hardware and unrelated software on work devices. [4]
- Disable local administrator rights for ordinary users. [2]
- Record where each device is expected to be and notice if that changes.
- Where policy and law allow, review sign-in locations. The FBI notes that fraudulent workers often log into one account many times in a short span from IP addresses tied to different countries. [2]
- Remember that monitoring staff is itself regulated. The ICO's employment hub includes guidance on monitoring workers. [8] Tell people what you monitor and why, keep it proportionate, and take advice before deploying anything that tracks individual behaviour.

Contractors and freelancers

Contractors are not second-class security citizens. The same logic applies: verify, stage, limit.

- **Verify the person, not the company.** If an agency sends someone, confirm that the individual who turns up is the individual you were told about, using the day-one welcome call and an ID check.

- **Use a written scope.** Say which systems and data the contractor may access, for how long, and from what devices.
- **Provide a separate account.** Do not share your own login. Give them a named account with an end date.
- **Prefer your devices or a controlled virtual environment** for work on sensitive systems.
- **Use reputable freelance platforms** and keep communication and payment inside them. Recorded Future advises caution about requests to communicate outside freelance platforms. [5]
- **Ask about subcontracting.** The FBI's October 2026 alert says workers also hire freelancers for remote labour, applications and interviews. [4] Write into the contract that the named individual does the work, and that substitution or subcontracting needs written approval.
- **End access at the end.** Put an end date on the account at creation and review it before extending.

Remote and hybrid staff

- Offer a short, written **remote-working standard**: use your managed device, keep it locked, do not let others use it, do not install remote-control software, report loss immediately. The ICO has guidance on working from home as part of its security materials. [8]
- Run a **brief "check-in" at 30, 60 and 90 days** that includes: do you have the access you need, do you have anything you should not have, have your contact details or payroll details changed?
- **Notice behaviour changes**: a person who never joins live calls with camera on, always misses in-person meetups despite living nearby, or whose work output is inconsistent with their apparent ability. Note, do not accuse. People have reasons. Recorded Future reports that some operators' interviews overlapped with meetings at jobs they already held, which led to manager

feedback about absences and poor performance. [5] Poor attendance has many innocent causes, so treat it as a prompt for a supportive conversation first.

Quarterly access review

Once a quarter, 60 minutes, two people:

1. Export the list of users for your main systems: email, cloud, code, finance, customer data.
2. Mark anyone who has left, changed role or is a contractor whose contract ended.
3. Mark anyone with admin rights or payment approval.
4. Ask each manager to confirm that their team's access is still right.
5. Remove or reduce anything that is not needed. Record the review.

It is the cheapest security control a small firm can run.

Illustrative example

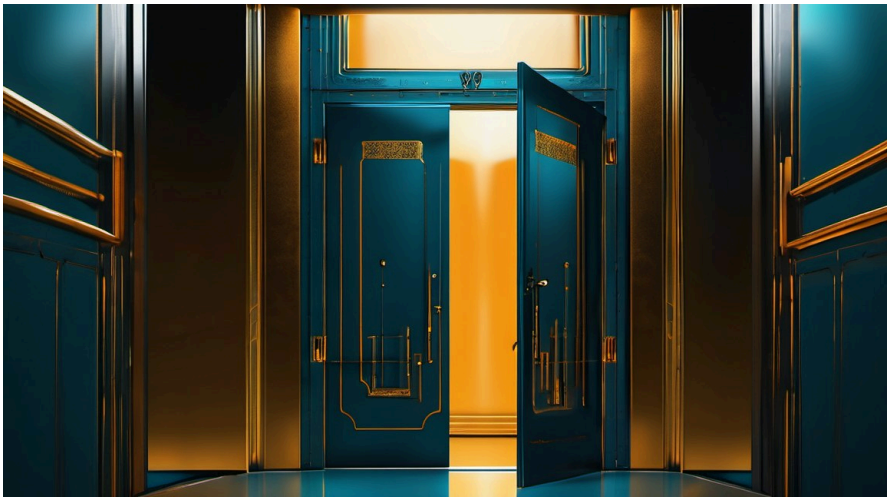
> **Illustrative example.** *Lumen Marketing*, an invented 22-person agency, brings in a freelance developer through a platform. The founder, Rui, used to share the CMS admin login. This time he creates a named account with editor rights only, valid for 60 days, enrols the freelancer in multi-factor authentication, and asks that work happens on a managed virtual desktop. The freelancer asks for admin rights in week two "to speed things up". Rui asks what specific task needs it, then grants a temporary role limited to that task, with a reminder to remove it. At the quarterly review, the account is closed on schedule. Nothing dramatic happened and that is exactly the point: the controls made the ordinary case smooth and the abnormal case visible.

This week

- ☐ Draw the access ladder for your company and write which tools belong at each stage.
- ☐ Switch on multi-factor authentication for all staff and contractors on your email and main cloud tools.
- ☐ Replace any shared logins with named accounts.
- ☐ Put an end date on every contractor account.
- ☐ Book the first 60-minute quarterly access review in your calendar.

CHAPTER 10

What to Do When a Candidate Seems Suspicious



The problem you may recognise

Something feels off. A candidate's answers do not quite fit, a reference seems too eager, or a new starter's laptop shows up logged in from an unexpected place. You are not sure whether to confront, ignore or investigate. If you accuse an honest person you could harm them and expose yourself to complaints. If you ignore a real fraud, you could be exposed to loss.

The risk in plain language

Both errors are costly. The way through is a **calm, pre-agreed procedure** that separates *observation* from *conclusion*. The FBI advises calibrating controls to limit false positives, requiring

substantive human review and refining based on outcomes. [4] You want a process that treats people fairly, collects facts, and escalates only when the facts justify it.

Three situations, three paths

Which path you follow depends on *when* the concern arises.

A. Before an offer

You have not hired anyone, so the stakes are lower. The core approach is **slow down, verify more, decide on evidence**.

1. **Write down what you observed**, in neutral language, with date and who noticed. "Candidate's described duties in the second interview differed from the first" is useful. "Seems dodgy" is not.
2. **Add verification, equally and openly.** Offer a second conversation with a different interviewer, a live ID check, and independent employment verification. Say plainly: "We carry out this step for all preferred candidates."
3. **Give the candidate a chance to clarify.** Ask neutral questions: "Could you help me understand the dates on this role?" Honest people usually have clear answers.
4. **Decide on the evidence.** If the file now supports the candidate, proceed. If it does not support an offer, you may decline to proceed. State only that you will not be taking the application forward. You do not have to explain every suspicion, and you should not accuse.

B. Between offer and start date

You have made a conditional offer (Chapter 8).

1. **Pause shipments and account activation.** Say "we're finalising checks", which is true.
2. **Run the missing verification steps**, including a live ID check and independent verification of address and payment details.

3. **Compare the evidence.** Does the person on the live check match the person you interviewed? Do the details line up?
4. **If verification fails or the person refuses all reasonable routes**, withdraw the offer in line with its conditions after taking advice, and keep the records.

C. After the person has started

This is the most serious situation, because they may already have access. The FBI's January 2025 advice for suspected compromise is to report the activity to IC3 as quickly as possible and review network activity from the suspected employee and their assigned devices. [2] The FBI's October 2026 alert recommends coordinating across HR, IT, security and management. [4] Recorded Future advises treating indicators of this kind as potential active compromise: review access privileges, software installation history and communications. [5]

Your sequence:

1. **Contain quietly.** Do not tip off the individual. Restrict or monitor access to the most sensitive systems, change shared credentials, and secure code and data. Involve IT or your IT supplier.
2. **Preserve evidence.** Keep logs, emails, messages and the device. Do not wipe or reinstall the device.
3. **Limit who knows.** Tell only those who need to know: the owner, the hiring-security lead, IT, and an employment or legal adviser.
4. **Take advice before acting on the individual.** Employment law, data-protection rules and (in the UK) right-to-work obligations may all be engaged. A hasty dismissal or a careless accusation can create problems of its own.
5. **Consider reporting.** The FBI asks for suspected activity to be reported to a local FBI field office and to IC3, with any addresses, identifiers, images and facilitator details. [4] In the UK, consider the police and Action Fraud, and if personal data may be involved, think about whether your obligations to notify a regulator or

affected people are triggered; get advice quickly because time limits can be short. The NCSC's small business guidance on response and recovery covers preparing for and responding to cyber incidents. [13]

6. **Review the hire's process.** Once the situation is under control, find out which check failed and fix it.

A neutral conversation script

If you decide to speak to the person, whether a candidate or an employee, keep it short, factual and the same as you would say to anyone.

1. **Open with the purpose.** *"I'd like to check a couple of details as part of our routine verification."*
2. **State the specific fact, not a conclusion.** *"Our records show the delivery address differs from the one on your documents. Can you help me understand that?"* Never say "we think you're lying."
3. **Listen and note.** Write down their explanation in their own words.
4. **Offer a route to resolve it.** *"The simplest way to settle this is a short live check. Could we do that tomorrow?"*
5. **Close without drawing a conclusion.** *"Thank you, we'll come back to you by [date]."*
6. **Take advice before any consequence.** Decide what happens next only after you have the facts and, for an employee, employment advice.

Have a second person present or take the notes, so there is a record. Do not record the conversation unless your policy and privacy notice allow it and you have taken advice.

What not to do

- **Do not publicly accuse** a candidate or employee, on social media or otherwise.
- **Do not confront** someone you suspect of being part of an organised scheme, particularly if there are signs of coercion. The FBI's October 2026 alert notes that some of these workers use extortion, threats and intimidation through facilitators. [4] Let advisers and authorities lead.
- **Do not retaliate technically.** Do not hack back, install spyware or access personal accounts.
- **Do not discard evidence**.
- **Do not blacklist on weak grounds.** Sharing allegations about a named person with other employers can create legal liability.
- **Do not assume the person is a perpetrator.** The real person whose identity was used may be a victim. The FBI notes that victims found their identities used in applications for jobs they never applied for. [1]

Keep a simple log

For each concern, keep a one-page record:

- date and time, who raised it, and what was observed;
- which checks were done, and the results;
- who was told, and what advice was sought;
- the decision taken and why.

Use neutral, factual language. This protects the candidate from unfair treatment and protects you if a decision is later challenged. Appendix G is a ready-made incident card.

Illustrative example

Illustrative example. *Elan Software*, an invented 16-person firm, onboarded a developer five weeks ago. During the quarterly review, the IT manager, Sofia, notices a remote-access tool on the developer's company laptop that IT never installed, and two logins on the same afternoon from different countries. Either could have an innocent explanation (a travelling employee, a tool installed for a legitimate reason). Sofia does not call the developer. She records what she saw, limits access to the production environment, and asks the owner to arrange a call with an employment adviser the same day. The adviser recommends a documented, neutral conversation with the developer and a live identity re-verification; meanwhile IT preserves logs. The developer gives a clear explanation for the travel and removes the unapproved tool; the access is restored with tighter controls. The next month Elan adds a rule that remote-access tools need prior approval. The process protected both sides.

This week

- ☐ Print the incident card (Appendix G) and agree who is the first point of contact at your company.
- ☐ Identify your employment adviser, IT supplier and insurer contacts now, so you are not searching for them during an incident.
- ☐ Find out your local reporting routes (in the US, IC3 and the local FBI field office [4]; in the UK, Action Fraud and the police; elsewhere, your national cybercrime and data-protection authorities).
- ☐ Agree who may suspend access and on whose authority.

- [ ] Run a 20-minute tabletop: "A new starter's laptop shows a remote-access tool we did not install. What do we do in the first hour?"

CHAPTER 11

A 30-Day Deepfake-Candidate Defence Plan



The problem you may recognise

You have read ten chapters of advice and your day job has not gone away. You need a way to turn this into something done, not a vague intention. This chapter gives you a 30-day plan that a busy owner or small team can do in short blocks.

The risk in plain language

The biggest risk to your defence is not a clever fraud; it is a good plan that never starts. The plan below is deliberately modest: roughly two to three hours a week, in four weekly themes. Appendix I is the same plan in a printable format.

Week 1: Decide and describe

Goal: know what you are protecting and who owns it.

- Name a **hiring-security owner** and a deputy.
- **Rate your roles** Low, Medium or High (Chapter 3).
- Write the **one-paragraph description** of how you currently confirm identity, then circle the gaps.
- Decide your **AI-assistance rule** for interviews and tests.
- List where applications and candidate data are stored and who can see them.
- Read the FBI's 2022 and 2025 alerts [1][2] and Recorded Future's research [5] together in 30 minutes, so everyone shares the same picture.

Done when: you have a named owner, rated roles and a list of gaps.

Week 2: Fix the front of the process

Goal: a fair, repeatable path from advert to preferred candidate.

- Update the **job advert template** with the verification statement and AI rule (Chapter 4).
- Adopt the **pre-interview screening checklist** (Appendix B) and the **video-interview protocol** (Appendix C).
- Write **core questions** and follow-ups for your next role (Chapter 5).
- Replace any test that uses real data with a **safe technical assessment** (Appendix D).
- Prepare the **reference-verification call script** (Appendix E).
- Brief everyone who interviews, using the Note / Check / Stop table.

Done when: your next vacancy can run on the new process without extra thought.

Week 3: Fix the back of the process

Goal: close the offer-to-onboarding gap and set up staged access.

- Add **conditional-offer** wording to your offer letter (Chapter 8).
- Choose your **identity-verification method** per risk level and set up a secure way to receive documents (Chapter 7).
- Write the **delivery-address and payroll-change rule**.
- Create the **access ladder** and a **new-hire access checklist** (Appendix F).
- Switch on **multi-factor authentication** for all staff and contractors.
- Schedule the **day-one welcome call**.

Done when: a new starter cannot receive a laptop or an account without passing through the checklist.

Week 4: Prepare for trouble and make it stick

Goal: rehearse the response and put the policy in writing.

- Print the **suspicious-candidate incident card** (Appendix G) and brief the people on it.
- Run a **20-minute tabletop exercise** using one of the scenarios from Chapter 10.
- Adopt the **one-page hiring-security policy** (Appendix H); have it reviewed by an employment adviser if possible.
- Book your first **quarterly access review**.
- Update your **privacy notice** for applicants: what you collect, why, how long you keep it.
- Ask your **agencies and IT supplier** the questions from Chapter 6 and Chapter 9.

Done when: the policy is signed off, the team has practised once and the review is in the diary.

Measuring whether it works

You do not need metrics dashboards. Four simple questions, once a quarter, tell you whether the system is alive:

1. Did every hire pass through the checklist? (Sample three files.)
2. How many verification steps changed an outcome or revealed a discrepancy, even innocently?
3. Did anyone experience the process as unfair or burdensome? (Ask candidates and new starters.)
4. Did the access review find anything that should not have been there?

Adjust the process based on the answers. The FBI advises tuning controls to limit false positives and refining based on outcomes. [4]

Sustaining it

- **Review the policy twice a year** and when you notice a new pattern. Official alerts are updated: the FBI published relevant alerts in 2022, 2025 and again in October 2026, and the October 2026 alert describes changes in tactics. [1][3][4]
- **Keep the owner supported.** A hiring-security owner needs time and authority, not just a title.
- **Train new interviewers** in 30 minutes using the protocol and the red-flag table.
- **Share the practice** with the agencies and suppliers you work with.

Illustrative example

> **Illustrative example.** *Pennant & Co.*, an invented 11-person consultancy, runs the 30-day plan between two other projects. The founder, Leila, spends Mondays and Thursdays on it. By week four they have a one-page policy, an updated job advert and a checklist in their shared drive. Three months later, they hire two people. Both go through the new steps. One asks why identity checks are needed; Leila points to the line in the advert; the candidate shrugs and completes it. Total extra time per hire: about ninety minutes. They also remove two old contractor accounts at their first access review. None of this made headlines, and that is what a good control looks like.

This week

- ☐ Block four short sessions in your calendar for the next four weeks.
- ☐ Name the owner and deputy, today.
- ☐ Print Appendix I and pin it where the team will see it.
- ☐ Tell the team: "We are making hiring safer and fairer. This is how."

Conclusion: Trust, but Build the Door



Hiring has always been an act of trust. You meet someone for a few hours, read what they say about themselves and decide to give them a place in your business, a login to your systems and, eventually, a say in your future. For most of the history of hiring, the main risk was that the person was less capable than they appeared.

The risk has widened. Video, CVs, portfolios and even references can now be produced, borrowed or coached. Official bodies have warned about deepfakes and stolen identities in remote-work applications [1], about facilitators and laptop farms [3], and about changing tactics as of October 2026. [4] Researchers have documented operators who run many fabricated personas at once and use AI to answer interview questions in character. [5] Hiring professionals themselves are worried: a vendor survey in the UK

found 69% of hiring leaders saw AI-enabled impersonation as the most sophisticated emerging threat, though the limits of that figure are worth remembering. [6]

You do not need to become a forensic analyst to respond. You need to do a few ordinary things consistently:

- **Treat what you see as evidence, not proof.** Verify identity through channels the candidate does not control.
- **Run one fair process for everyone.** Same questions, same checks, same stages, clearly explained.
- **Verify before you trust, and trust in steps.** Conditional offers, careful shipping, staged access, named accounts, second sets of eyes on money.
- **Write down what you notice, and escalate calmly.** Note, check, then stop and escalate only on strong grounds.
- **Stay fair.** The best security process is one that honest candidates barely notice and that never treats a difference as a danger.

If you remember only three sentences from this book, let them be these. *Video tells you someone is there; it does not tell you who they are. Do not give access until the person is verified. And when something feels off, slow down and follow your process rather than your suspicion.*

A last thought about the people on the other side of the screen. The overwhelming majority of candidates are honest, anxious and hoping you will give them a chance. A good verification process is a form of respect for them: it protects their identity from being borrowed, it protects the job from going to an impostor, and it protects the colleagues they will work with. Done well, it is also a mark of a well-run company, and candidates notice.

The appendices that follow are for printing, adapting and using. Start with the one-page policy and the thirty-day plan. Tomorrow's hire will be safer for it.

APPENDIX A

Candidate Verification Checklist

Complete for the preferred candidate before an offer becomes unconditional. Use the same list for every candidate in the same role. Store the completed form in the candidate's file, not in email.

Candidate name: _____ **Role:** _____ **Risk level (L / M / H):** _____

Completed by: _____ **Date:** _____

1. Identity

- ☐ Candidate informed in advance of what will be checked and why
- ☐ Live identity check completed (certified digital check, or live human-assisted check using the video-interview protocol)
- ☐ Name on the document matches the name on the application and offer
- ☐ Photo on the document consistent with the person on the live call
- ☐ Alternative route offered where the candidate could not complete the standard method
- ☐ Evidence stored securely; access limited to named people

2. Right to work (where applicable)

- ☐ Method appropriate to the candidate chosen (for example, share code, digital check or manual check) in line with current official guidance
- ☐ Check completed **before** the start date
- ☐ Date of the check recorded; copies retained as required
- ☐ Follow-up date set if the right to work is time-limited

3. History

- ☐ Employment verified directly with the employer, using contact details found independently
- ☐ Education or qualifications verified directly with the institution or awarding body (if relevant to the role)
- ☐ Two references obtained under the reference script (Appendix E), or equivalent alternatives
- ☐ Dates, titles and locations consistent across CV, interview, references and public profiles

4. Consistency

- ☐ Phone number and email address not shared with another applicant or identity
- ☐ Application details compared with other applicants for the same role
- ☐ Location and time zone consistent throughout the file
- ☐ Interviewers confirm the same person attended each stage (Y / N, notes)

5. Onboarding details

- ☐ Delivery address matches the verified address; any change documented with evidence
- ☐ Bank account name matches the verified name
- ☐ Payroll details entered by one person and approved by another
- ☐ Day-one welcome call scheduled

6. Concerns

- ☐ None, **or** concerns recorded neutrally on the incident card (Appendix G)

Decision: ☐ Proceed ☐ Pause for further verification ☐ Do not proceed

Signed (verifier): _____ **Second reviewer (High roles):** _____

APPENDIX B

Pre-Interview Screening Checklist

Use at shortlist stage. These are prompts for follow-up, never grounds for automatic rejection. Apply the same checks to every shortlisted candidate.

Candidate: _____ **Role:** _____ **Screened by:** _____

Job-related fit (scored against criteria written before reading applications)

- ☐ Criterion 1: _____ Met / Partly / Not met
- ☐ Criterion 2: _____ Met / Partly / Not met
- ☐ Criterion 3: _____ Met / Partly / Not met
- ☐ Criterion 4: _____ Met / Partly / Not met

Consistency prompts

- ☐ CV timeline hangs together (allowing for breaks, study, caring, illness)
- ☐ No identical or near-identical wording, phone number or email address in another application
- ☐ Phone number is not obviously a temporary or shared internet number (if so, note and ask a neutral question)
- ☐ Referee contact details are on organisational domains, or the candidate explained why not
- ☐ Public professional profile (where one exists) is broadly consistent; absence is not a concern in itself
- ☐ Application arrived through the official route; any request to move to another app was noted

Fairness safeguards

☐ Screening did not use name, nationality, accent, age, photo, country of study or disability as a factor

☐ No automatic rejection by software; a person reviewed the decision

☐ Reasonable adjustments offered for the interview if requested

Outcome

☐ Invite to interview ☐ Hold, request clarification ☐ Not progressing (job-related reason): _____

Notes (neutral, factual):

_____

_____

APPENDIX C

Video-Interview Protocol

A short, repeatable script. Use it for every video interview. It creates friction for impostors, not distress for honest candidates.

Before the interview

1. Send the invitation from your normal business address with the link on a platform you control.
2. Include this paragraph: "*This will be a video interview. Please join with your camera on in a space that is reasonably clear, with a stable connection. We ask everyone to do this. If you need any adjustment, such as for accessibility, privacy or connectivity, tell us in advance and we will arrange an alternative. We also carry out identity checks for all hires, at a later stage.*"
3. State your AI-assistance rule in the same message.
4. Brief the interviewers on the questions, the Note / Check / Stop table (Chapter 5) and the fairness reminders.

At the start of the call (two minutes)

1. Introduce everyone. Check the candidate can see and hear you.
2. Say: "*We ask all candidates to do a quick check that the video is working. Could you move your camera slightly so we can see your workspace, and wave a hand in front of your face?*" The FBI suggests these as ways to disrupt some AI-generated video. [3] Make it light and universal. A glitch is a note, not a verdict.
3. Confirm the candidate's name and ask which time zone they are working in.
4. Remind them of the AI rule: "*We'd like your own answers in this conversation. Please don't use AI assistants or have anyone helping.*"

During the interview

1. Ask the core questions in the same order for every candidate.
2. Use two follow-up probes on at least two answers.
3. Include one unscripted or screen-share element.
4. Make a brief neutral note of anything inconsistent: facts, not feelings.
5. Do not ask about age, nationality, health, family plans or immigration status.

At the end

1. Explain the next steps and mention that preferred candidates complete an identity check.
2. Ask: *"Is there anything we could do to make the next stage easier for you?"*
3. Immediately after the call, each interviewer records Note / Check / Stop independently before talking to others.

Live identity check (separate session, preferred candidate, by a trained person who was not in the interviews)

1. Explain what will happen and why, and offer the alternative route.
2. Ask the candidate to hold the original photo ID to the camera, front and back, in good light, and to bring it close enough to see details.
3. Compare the photo with the person on the call; check that the name matches the application; look for obvious signs of alteration, such as misspellings or damage. [3]
4. Record the result (match / no match / unable to verify) and what was checked. Do not take screenshots unless your policy and privacy notice allow it.
5. If unable to verify, offer another route (certified digital check, in-person check, alternative documents).

APPENDIX D

Safe Technical-Assessment Checklist

Use when designing any practical test, take-home exercise or trial.

Design

- ☐ The task reflects real job duties and takes a reasonable time (state the time limit)
- ☐ All data used is fictional or fully sanitised
- ☐ No real credentials, API keys, customer names, internal URLs or confidential code are included
- ☐ The test sits in a throwaway environment with no link to production
- ☐ The candidate uses their own tools or a controlled browser-based environment; nobody is asked to install software on a personal device
- ☐ Reasonable adjustments are available (extra time, format changes) on request

Rules

- ☐ AI and tools policy stated in writing before the test (allowed / allowed with disclosure / not allowed)
- ☐ Rule on help from others stated
- ☐ Candidate told how their work and personal data will be used, stored and deleted

Review

- ☐ A live walkthrough follows the test: "Explain your approach; now change this part"
- ☐ More than one reviewer assesses against written criteria

- ☐ Anything unusual recorded neutrally and compared with other evidence
- ☐ No decision based on the test alone

After

- ☐ Test materials and submissions removed from the throwaway environment
- ☐ Records retained or deleted according to your retention period
- ☐ Candidate receives timely feedback

Never

- ☐ Give a candidate access to real systems, data or accounts before verification and offer
- ☐ Accept a request to install remote-access software on your device
- ☐ Use a candidate's work for real business purposes without permission and payment

APPENDIX E

Reference-Verification Call Script

Use for every reference, in the same order. Source the referee's contact details independently.

Before the call

- ☐ Candidate gave permission to contact this referee, and knows who will be called
- ☐ Contact details found through the organisation's official website or switchboard
- ☐ Employment dates and job title confirmed with the organisation first, if possible

Opening

"Hello, I'm [name] from [company]. [Candidate name] has applied for a [role] with us and gave your name as a referee, with their permission. Do you have ten minutes? Before we start, could I check that I'm speaking to the right person: what is your role at [organisation], and how long have you been there?"

Verification questions

1. *"Can you confirm that [candidate] worked at [organisation]? In what role, and for what dates?"*
2. *"What was your working relationship, and for how long?"*
3. *"Was [candidate] employed or engaged on a contract?"*

Substance (same questions for each referee)

4. *"What were their main responsibilities?"*
5. *"Can you give an example of something they delivered that you were pleased with?"*
6. *"Where did they need most support or development?"*

7. *"How did they work with others, and how did they deal with pressure or disagreement?"*
8. *"Would you work with them again? Is there anything we should know to help them succeed?"*

Identity consistency (light touch)

9. *"Is there a way you worked with them that you could describe, for example in person, by video or entirely remotely?"* (Listen for consistency with the CV and for whether the referee could recognise the person.)

Closing

"Thank you. This will be kept confidential and used only for this recruitment."

After the call

- ☐ Notes recorded the same day in neutral language
- ☐ Comparison with CV and other references completed
- ☐ Anything inconsistent noted and followed up equally for all candidates

Signals to follow up (never grounds for automatic rejection)

- Referee unavailable except by webmail or a messaging app
- Unusually fast, generic or glowing replies [2]
- Referee cannot confirm employment through the organisation's main contact
- Replies in a style similar to the candidate's CV or interview answers
- Referee vague about the candidate's actual work

If the candidate has no conventional referee: accept an alternative such as a client, collaborator, tutor or a professional body, and apply the same verification steps.

APPENDIX F

New-Hire Access Checklist

Complete for every new starter. No account activated until Section 1 is signed.

New starter: _____ **Role:** _____ **Start date:** _____ **Risk level:** L / M / H

1. Release conditions (all required before shipping a device or enabling accounts)

- ☐ Identity verified (Appendix A complete)
- ☐ Right-to-work check complete where applicable
- ☐ References / employment verification complete
- ☐ Delivery address matches the verified address; any alternative evidenced
- ☐ Bank details verified; entered and approved by different people
- ☐ Conditional-offer conditions met
- ☐ **Approved to proceed by (name):** _____ Date: _____

2. Device

- ☐ Company-managed device assigned; serial number and recipient recorded
- ☐ Sent by trackable service with signature on delivery
- ☐ Device enrolled in management software on first start
- ☐ Local administrator rights disabled for the user [2]
- ☐ Remote-access / remote-management tools blocked, or alert set [4]
- ☐ Equipment acknowledgment signed (no sharing, no remote-control tools, report loss)

3. Accounts and access

- ☐ Named individual account (no shared logins)
- ☐ Multi-factor authentication enabled before first use
- ☐ Access ladder stage assigned (1 Starter / 2 Working / 3 Trusted / 4 Privileged)
- ☐ Access to customer data, code, finance or admin tools **not** granted at Stage 1
- ☐ "Needs / may need / never needs" list completed
- ☐ End date set for any contractor or temporary access

4. Day one

- ☐ Welcome call on camera: name confirmed, same person as verified, manager present
- ☐ Policy briefing: hiring-security, acceptable use, how to report concerns
- ☐ Day-one tasks limited to the Starter stage

5. Reviews

- ☐ 30-day check-in: access needed / not needed; any detail changes (address, payroll)
- ☐ 60- and 90-day check-ins scheduled
- ☐ Access review at end of probation recorded
- ☐ Next quarterly access review date: _____

APPENDIX G

Suspicious-Candidate Incident Card

Keep this where the hiring team can find it. Principle: observe, don't accuse; verify equally; escalate only on evidence.

Incident reference: _____ **Date raised:** _____ **Raised by:** _____

Stage: ☐ Before offer ☐ Offer to start ☐ After start

1. What was observed (facts only)

_____

_____

2. Level: ☐ Note ☐ Check ☐ Stop and escalate

3. First actions (tick as done)

- ☐ Wrote down the observation neutrally, with time and date
- ☐ Told **only** the hiring-security owner
- ☐ Applied extra verification openly and equally (second interviewer, live ID check, independent employment check)
- ☐ If an employee or contractor: restricted sensitive access without tipping off
- ☐ Preserved evidence (logs, emails, messages); did **not** wipe or reinstall any device
- ☐ Changed shared credentials or secrets if exposure was possible

4. Escalation (Stop level)

- ☐ Informed owner / director
- ☐ Called employment adviser (name/number: _____)

- ☐ Called IT supplier or security contact (_____)
- ☐ Considered legal duties to report or notify (data-protection regulator, affected people, insurer, customers) and took advice on timing
- ☐ Considered reporting to authorities: in the US the FBI IC3 and the local FBI field office [4]; in the UK, Action Fraud and police; elsewhere, national cybercrime authorities
- ☐ Documented decisions and who authorised them

5. Do not

- ☐ Accuse the individual publicly
- ☐ Confront someone you suspect is part of an organised scheme
- ☐ Retaliate technically or access personal accounts
- ☐ Share allegations about a named person outside those who need to know
- ☐ Assume the person named is the offender. They may be a victim of identity theft [1]

6. Outcome and learning

Decision:

_____

Date: _____

Which check would have caught this earlier?

_____

Process change made:

_____

APPENDIX H

One-Page Hiring-Security Policy for Small Businesses

Adapt to your business. Have an employment or legal adviser review it before adoption. Version: _____ *Date:* _____ *Owner:* _____

1. Purpose. We want to hire the right people safely and fairly. We verify identity and protect access so that our customers, our team and our business are not put at risk by a fraudulent or unverified hire.

2. Scope. All employees, contractors, freelancers and agency workers, for remote, hybrid or on-site roles.

3. Principles. We treat video, CVs, portfolios and references as evidence, not proof. We apply the same process to every candidate for a role. We collect only the data we need. We never discriminate. We verify before we trust, and we trust in stages.

4. Roles and responsibilities. The hiring-security owner (_____) maintains this policy, trains interviewers and handles escalations. Hiring managers follow the process. IT controls accounts and devices. Directors approve exceptions in writing.

5. Risk rating. Each role is rated Low, Medium or High before advertising, based on the most damaging thing a bad hire could do.

6. Advertising and screening. Adverts state our verification process and our AI-assistance rules. Shortlisting uses criteria written in advance. Consistency checks are prompts for follow-up, never for automatic rejection.

7. Interviews. We use structured questions and the video-interview protocol. We do not decide on appearance, accent, name, nationality or similar characteristics.

8. Assessments. Tests use fictional data, never real systems or credentials, and are followed by a live walkthrough.

9. Verification. Preferred candidates complete a live identity check against government photo ID using a secure method, with an alternative route offered. Right-to-work checks are completed before the start date in line with current law. Employment and, where relevant, education are verified directly with the source. Identity documents are never accepted by ordinary email.

10. Offers and onboarding. Offers are conditional on completed checks. Devices ship only to the verified address. Payroll details are entered and approved by different people. Accounts stay disabled until a named person confirms checks are complete. A live welcome call takes place on day one.

11. Access. Access is staged and minimal. Everyone uses a named account with multi-factor authentication. Shared logins are not allowed. Contractor access has an end date. Remote-access software is installed only with IT approval. Access is reviewed every quarter.

12. Concerns. Anyone who has a concern tells the hiring-security owner. We record facts neutrally, verify equally, preserve evidence and take advice before acting against an individual. We do not accuse or retaliate.

13. Data protection. Candidate and employee data is stored in approved systems, restricted to people who need it, and kept only as long as our retention schedule allows. Our applicant privacy notice explains this.

14. Review. The policy is reviewed twice a year and after any incident.

Approved by: _____ Date: _____

APPENDIX I

30-Day Implementation Plan

Week	Actions	Done
1: Decide and describe	Name hiring-security owner and deputy; rate all current and planned roles Low / Medium / High; write a paragraph describing today's identity checks and circle the gaps; decide the AI-assistance rule; list where candidate data is stored and who has access; read the FBI alerts and Recorded Future research together	☐
2: Fix the front	Add the verification statement and AI rule to the job advert; adopt Appendices B and C; write core interview questions; replace any test that uses real data (Appendix D); prepare the reference script (Appendix E); brief interviewers on Note / Check / Stop	☐
3: Fix the back	Add conditional-offer wording; choose identity-check methods per risk level and set up secure document handling; write the address and payroll change rule; build the access ladder and use Appendix F; switch on multi-factor authentication for everyone; schedule day-one welcome calls	☐
4: Prepare and embed	Print and brief the incident card (Appendix G); run a 20-minute tabletop; adopt the one-page policy (Appendix H) after adviser review; update the applicant privacy notice; ask agencies and suppliers the Chapter 6 and 9 questions; book the first quarterly access review	☐

Day 31 and beyond

- ☐ Sample three hiring files: did each pass through the checklist?
- ☐ Ask recent candidates and new starters whether the process felt fair and clear
- ☐ Review policy at six months, and after any incident
- ☐ Check the FBI's IC3 site, GOV.UK and the ICO's employment hub for updated guidance [4][9][8]

Book Description

Who Are You Hiring? The Small-Business Playbook for Stopping Deepfake Candidates, Identity Fraud, and Risky Remote Onboarding

The person you interviewed on video may not be the person who starts work on Monday.

Official warnings now describe stolen identities, AI-assisted interviews and facilitators who receive company laptops on behalf of workers elsewhere. Researchers have documented operators running many fake personas at once. And most small businesses have no security team to catch it. You do not need one.

Who Are You Hiring? is a calm, practical, plain-English guide for founders, owners, HR leads, hiring managers and IT managers who hire remote or hybrid staff. It does not ask you to spot deepfakes by staring at a video, because that approach fails. It gives you a repeatable, fair process that makes a fake candidate's job much harder and an honest candidate's job barely different.

Inside you will learn how to:

- understand the real risks of a bad hire: access, data, money and reputation
- write job adverts and screen applications without creating bias
- run structured video interviews with fair, simple friction
- design safe technical tests and verify portfolios, references and agencies
- handle identity and right-to-work checks in a proportionate, privacy-conscious way
- close the dangerous gap between the offer and the first day

- control access for new hires, contractors and remote devices, one stage at a time
- respond calmly and lawfully when a candidate seems suspicious
- put the whole system in place with a 30-day plan

Every chapter starts with a problem you will recognise, explains the risk in simple language, gives a realistic (clearly labelled illustrative) example and ends with actions you can take this week. The appendices are ready-to-use tools: a candidate verification checklist, pre-interview screening checklist, video-interview protocol, safe-assessment checklist, reference-call script, new-hire access checklist, suspicious-candidate incident card, a one-page hiring-security policy and a 30-day implementation plan.

Built on current public guidance and research, including FBI IC3 alerts, Recorded Future research, UK recruitment-integrity research and UK data-protection and right-to-work guidance, with linked sources throughout.

This is practical guidance, not legal, employment, immigration or data-protection advice.

Keywords: hiring security, deepfake candidates, remote hiring fraud, identity verification, small business HR, remote onboarding, insider risk, recruitment fraud

Sources and Further Reading

All sources were opened and read in late October 2026 unless noted. Web pages change; confirm the current text before relying on a source. Vendor surveys are marked as such.

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2. FBI IC3, Public Service Announcement I-012325-PSA, 23 January 2025 (guidance on North Korean IT workers: recommended employer actions and red flags). https://www.ic3.gov/PSA/2025/PSA250123
3. FBI IC3, Public Service Announcement I-072325-4-PSA, 23 July 2025 (additional guidance on North Korean IT workers, facilitators, laptop farms and contracted IT work). https://www.ic3.gov/PSA/2025/PSA250723-4
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6. First Advantage (UK), *AI candidate identity-fraud emerges as top recruitment challenge for UK employers in 2026*. A background-screening vendor's release; sample size and method are not stated. https://fadv.com/en-gb/blog/ai-candidate-identity-fraud-emerges-as-top-recruitment-challenge-for-uk-employers-in-2026/
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1. National Cyber Security Centre (NCSC), *Cyber Action Toolkit*. https://cybertoolkit.service.ncsc.gov.uk/
2. NCSC, *Cyber Essentials* overview. https://www.ncsc.gov.uk/cyberessentials/overview
3. NCSC, *Small Business Guide: Response and Recovery*. https://www.ncsc.gov.uk/collection/small-business-guidance--response-and-recovery

A note on the UK recruitment-integrity research. The only UK research on AI impersonation and deepfakes in recruitment that could be located and read in full was the First Advantage release above [6]. Other press coverage repeated the same figure. No equivalent report from a UK trade body or regulator was found. If you know of one, treat it as a welcome addition to your reading, and weigh vendor-sourced figures with care.

A note on legal references. Statements about UK GDPR principles, special-category data, the Equality Act and similar general legal concepts are background orientation, not citations to a source read for this book. Check them with a qualified adviser. Rules on right to work, which changed around 1 October 2026, should always be checked against the current GOV.UK guidance. [9][10]

Further reading

- ICO, guidance on UK GDPR and employment, including future final versions of the recruitment and selection guidance [7][8]

- GOV.UK, employer right-to-work guidance and the *Check if someone can work in the UK* service [9][10]
- NCSC, Small Business Guide and Cyber Essentials [11][12][13]
- FBI IC3, public service announcements archive, for later updates to [1]–[4]: https://www.ic3.gov/PSA

About the Author

Zirlandia Milkovic writes practical guides on data protection, digital risk and responsible technology for small businesses. This book grew out of a simple observation: the hiring process most small firms use was built for a world in which pretending to be somebody else was hard. It no longer is, and the fix does not need a security team.

Who Are You Hiring? is educational guidance, not legal, employment, immigration or data-protection advice.